

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Study Notes (Tyndale)

MRK

Mark 1:1

- Mark begins with an introduction. This gospel is about Jesus. In each story in Mark, we should ask, "What is Mark teaching about Jesus in this passage?"
- *Gospel*: This is a common term in Mark (see [1:14–15](#); [8:35](#); [10:29](#); [13:10](#); [14:9](#)). It can also be translated as *good news*. The gospel is the good news about Jesus. See study note on Mark 1:15.
- The Hebrew word *mashiakh* (Messiah) has the same meaning as the Greek term *christos* (Christ). Both mean "anointed one." In the Old Testament, the people of Israel anointed:
 - priests ([Exodus 28:41](#); [Leviticus 16:32](#); [21:10](#)),
 - kings ([2 Samuel 1:14](#), [16](#); [19:21](#); [Psalm 2](#)), and
 - prophets ([1 Kings 19:16](#)).

They anointed them with olive oil to show the Lord's presence, blessing, and authority for the tasks God gave them.

Over time, Israelites increasingly anticipated the Messiah, "the anointed one." He would be a descendant of King David, who would be Israel's king. The political associations of this title in the first century led Jesus to avoid openly declaring himself as the Messiah (see [Mark 3:11–12](#); [8:27–30](#); [14:61–63](#); [15:2](#), [26](#); [John 4:25–26](#)).

- *The Son of God*: This title emphasizes the special relationship between Jesus and God the Father ([Mark 1:11](#); [9:7](#); [12:4–6](#); [14:61–62](#)).

Mark 1:2–3

Mark includes Old Testament prophecies to support his account of the Good News about Jesus Christ. John the Baptist's role as the prophetic messenger reveals that Jesus is the promised Lord—Christ, the Son of God. • Isaiah: Mark follows the Jewish practice of mentioning only the most prominent of the sources that make up the quotation ([Mal 3:1](#); [Isa 40:3](#)).

Mark 1:2–8

This account does not focus mainly on John the Baptist, the messenger. Instead, it is about the one whom he announces as Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#)).

Mark 1:3

John the Baptist was the *voice of one calling in the wilderness*, urging people to prepare for the Lord's coming. In the book of Isaiah, this prophecy speaks of the coming of the Lord, the God of Israel. Here, it refers to the Lord Jesus (see [12:35–37](#)). The early church called itself "the Way," likely referring to this promise (see [Acts 9:2](#); [19:9](#), [23](#); [22:4](#); [24:14](#), [22](#); compare [Acts 2:28](#); [18:25–26](#); [Romans 2:20](#); [2 Peter 2:2](#), [21](#)).

Mark 1:4

- John's mission as the Lord's messenger was to prepare people for the arrival of the Messiah (see [Luke 1:76-77](#)). He instructed them to confess their sins, seek God's forgiveness, and be baptized. Those who did this were ready to receive the message of Jesus (see [Luke 7:29-30](#)).
- John was in the wilderness, likely the desert area around the Jordan River north of the Dead Sea. This shows he was the "voice" Isaiah mentioned ([Mark 1:3](#)).
- *preaching a baptism*: The exact origin of John's baptism is uncertain. The Qumran community practiced a "baptism" when someone became a part of the community, which they repeated regularly. But John's baptism was a one-time event. Jewish baptism for those converting to Judaism is another possible source, but it is more likely that such baptisms were not practiced until after John's ministry.

Mark 1:5

All of Judea: John the Baptist created a lot of interest. It was generally believed that there had been no prophet for over 400 years, so prophets were associated with Israel's past and with the future reign of the Messiah. John preached repentance like the ancient prophets, and he dressed like the great prophet Elijah ([1:6](#)), who was predicted to return in the last days ([Mal 4:5](#)).

Mark 1:6

camel hair . . . leather belt: Cp. Elijah ([2 Kgs 1:8](#)). • For food John ate what was available in the wilderness; locusts were allowed as food (cp. [Lev 11:20-24](#)).

Mark 1:7

Someone is coming: John knew that he was preparing for the Messiah's coming, but he did not yet know that Jesus was he (cp. [Luke 7:18-23](#)).

Mark 1:8

John's baptism prepared people for God's Kingdom by calling them to repentance. The baptism of Jesus brought the gift of the Holy Spirit, through whom sinful people become God's children ([Rom 8:15-16](#); [1 Cor 12:13](#); [Gal 4:6](#)).

Mark 1:9

Jesus' home at this time was in Nazareth, a small town in lower Galilee ([Matt 2:19-23](#); [Luke 2:39](#)). Jesus soon left Nazareth for Capernaum, a city on the Sea of Galilee ([Matt 4:13](#)). • John baptized him: Jesus' reason for receiving the baptism of repentance is explained in [Matt 3:14-15](#).

Mark 1:10

The expression the heavens splitting apart indicates Jesus' unique access to God the Father; in [15:38](#), the same verb includes believers in that access through Jesus' death. • All four Gospels refer to the Spirit descending on him like a dove. The Spirit, who was involved in the first creation, acted with Jesus in bringing the new creation ([Gen 1:2](#); [Rom 8:15-17](#); [1 Cor 6:11](#); [Eph 1:13-14](#); [2 Thes 2:13](#)).

Mark 1:11

You are my dearly loved Son: By age twelve, Jesus was aware of his unique relationship with God the Father ([Luke 2:49](#)).

Mark 1:12-13

The Spirit then compelled Jesus (cp. [Matt 4:1](#); [Luke 4:1](#)): Jesus was victorious over Satan and temptation from the beginning of his ministry; the later exorcisms ([Mark 1:21-34](#); [3:11-12](#); [5:1-20](#); [9:14-27](#)) are an outworking of that victory (see [3:27](#)). • Jesus was tempted in the wilderness of

Judea. Satan and wild animals ([Isa 13:19–22](#); [Ezek 34:25](#)) give the wilderness an evil aura. The wild animals included dogs, wolves, leopards, jackals, and bears. • The period of forty days recalls Israel's forty years of testing in the wilderness. Israel failed, but Jesus was victorious—he was tempted without sinning ([Heb 2:18](#); [4:15](#); cp. [Jas 1:3](#), [12](#); [1 Pet 1:7](#); [Rev 2:10](#)).

Mark 1:14

Jesus' ministry is described as beginning after John was arrested. There was some overlap ([John 3:22–24](#); [4:1–2](#)), but most of Jesus' ministry occurred after John's. John also belongs primarily to the old order ([Matt 11:7–14](#)), while Jesus belongs primarily to the new. Both men fulfilled God's plan through being arrested and executed ([Mark 6:14–29](#); [9:31](#); [10:33](#)). Jesus began preaching in Galilee at this time, but [John 2:13–4:43](#) suggests that Jesus had had an earlier ministry in Judea.

Mark 1:14–15

This summary introduces [1:14–3:6](#). Such summaries (see also [3:7–12](#); [6:6](#)) help hearers understand what follows; most of Mark's original audience would have heard the Gospel read aloud.

Mark 1:15

Jesus' preaching is summarized by his announcement that the Kingdom of God had come, and that people needed to repent and believe the Good News about the Messiah ([1:1](#)). • The Kingdom of God is not tied to a territory; it dynamically began in Jesus' person and extended to his followers. • In response to the arrival of God's Kingdom, people are called to repent (to turn from sin and yield to God) and to have faith in God's Good News. In Jesus' time, the Good News was the arrival of God's reign through the Messiah. For Mark's later audience, it was the news of Jesus' death, resurrection, ascension, and promised return ([15:1–16:8](#)). All people, Jews and Gentiles alike, need God's forgiveness through repentance and faith in Jesus.

Mark 1:16–20

The call of the two pairs of brothers—Simon and Andrew, James and John—followed an earlier encounter with Jesus ([John 1:35–42](#)).

Mark 1:17

Mark uses Jesus' invitation—Come, follow me ([1:20](#); [8:34](#))—and the expression “to follow him” ([1:18](#); [2:14–15](#); [3:7](#); [5:24](#)) to indicate what it means to be a Christian (see “Following Jesus” Theme Note).

Mark 1:19–20

Zebedee's sons . . . leaving their father: Jesus later taught that this is the kind of thing that his followers will do ([8:34–35](#); [Matt 10:37–39](#)).

Mark 1:21

Mark introduces his first account of an exorcism with Jesus and his companions going into the synagogue in Capernaum. Jesus' teaching in the synagogue suggests that he already had a reputation as a teacher and was therefore invited to speak (cp. [Acts 13:15](#)).

Mark 1:21–28

Jesus' exorcisms reveal Jesus' identity and his power over Satan (see study notes on Mark 1:12–13 and 3:27; see also [1:34](#), [39](#); [3:11–12](#), [22](#); [5:1–20](#); [6:13](#); [7:24–30](#); [9:14–29](#)).

Mark 1:22

The teachers of religious law were professional scribes—scholars who taught, copied, and interpreted Jewish law for the people. They were primarily associated with the Pharisees. The scribes' authority was derived from quoting other scribes (cp. [Matt 5:21–48](#)). Jesus' teaching caused amazement because he spoke and acted with real authority (see [Mark 1:27](#); [5:20](#); [6:2](#); [7:37](#); [10:24–32](#); [11:18](#); [15:5](#)).

Mark 1:23-24

The demon spoke through the man who was possessed by an evil spirit ([1:24](#)). Demons frequently cause disease ([9:17, 27](#); [Matt 17:15](#)) and self-destructive behavior ([Mark 1:26](#); [5:2-5](#); [9:17-18, 20-22](#)). Demons know who Jesus is ([1:34](#)); they consistently testify that he is the Holy One of God (see [3:11](#); [5:7](#)). • In saying us, the evil spirit spoke on behalf of all demons. It recognized Jesus' complete authority and understood that he had come to interfere with and destroy evil.

Mark 1:25

Jesus did not need to shout or utter magic words. He simply spoke with the authority of the Son of God ([1:1](#)), and the evil spirit obeyed. • Be quiet! Jesus commanded the evil spirit not to make him known. This is an instance of the "messianic secret," an expression for passages in Mark in which Jesus commands demons or people not to reveal his identity ([1:25, 34](#); [3:11-12](#); [8:30](#); [9:9](#)).

Mark 1:26

The screams and convulsions caused by the evil (literally *unclean*; also in [1:27](#)) spirit were its parting cries of defeat ([5:13](#); [9:26](#); cp. [15:37](#)).

Mark 1:27-28

The amazement caused by this exorcism quickly led to the spread of the news about Jesus. • What sort of new teaching is this? Jesus' healings and exorcisms were understood holistically as being part of his teaching ([1:21-22, 27](#); cp. [1:38-39](#); [3:14-15](#); [6:2, 5, 12-13, 30](#)).

Mark 1:29-30

Simon (Peter) was married (see [1 Cor 9:5](#)).

Mark 1:31

Jesus healed Simon's mother-in-law instantaneously (see also [1:40-45](#); [2:1-12](#); [3:1-6](#); [5:25-34](#); [7:31-37](#); [8:22-26](#); [10:46-52](#)).

Mark 1:32-34

These public healings took place after sunset following the Sabbath ([1:21, 29](#)), and there were many witnesses (see also [1:39](#); [3:10-11](#); [6:5, 53-56](#)).

Mark 1:33

Jesus' popularity among the crowds was growing (also in [1:37, 39, 45](#)), as contrasted with the growing rejection by the leaders ([2:1-3:6](#)).

Mark 1:34

the demons knew who he was: See [1:23-25](#).

Mark 1:35

Despite Jesus' busy ministry, he sought time to pray ([6:46](#); [14:32-39](#)). Mark emphasizes the importance of prayer in Jesus' life (cp. [Luke 3:21](#); [6:12](#); [9:18, 28-29](#); [11:1-4](#); [18:1](#); [22:32](#)).

Mark 1:38-39

Prayer ([1:35](#)) equipped Jesus to preach, teach, heal, and cast out demons. • Jesus' mission in Galilee centered on preaching in the synagogues, where he took the opportunity to speak ([1:21](#); [Luke 4:16-30](#)). Paul later used this same opportunity ([Acts 13:5, 14-15](#); [14:1](#); [16:13](#); [17:1](#)). • Jesus counted on Jewish hospitality when he traveled (cp. [Mark 6:10](#); [Gen 18:1-8](#); [19:1-8](#); [Luke 10:7](#); [Heb 13:2](#); [3 Jn 1:5-8](#)). • The region of Galilee was roughly forty miles north to south and twenty-five miles east to west (sixty-five by forty kilometers). In Jesus' day, Galilee was ruled by Herod Antipas.

Mark 1:40

Leprosy refers to a number of skin diseases (or even mildew in a building). An infected person was considered unclean and was ostracized from family and society ([Lev 13:45-46](#); [Num 12:9-12](#); [2 Chr 26:16-21](#); [Luke 17:12](#)).

Mark 1:41

Jesus' willingness to touch a ceremonially unclean leper reflects the new order of the Kingdom of God ([1:15](#); [5:25-34](#); [Luke 7:36-50](#); see [Matt 10:8](#); [11:5](#)).

Mark 1:43-45

Jesus told the man to go to the priest to certify his healing and to make the appropriate sacrificial offering. This would be the public testimony of his healing. • Despite Jesus' stern warning, . . . the man went and spread the word, so that Jesus was not able to go into town but had to preach in more secluded places. Jesus' fame could not be confined as people from everywhere came to see him ([3:7-8](#)).

Mark 2:1

back home: See [Matt 4:13](#). The crowd's size shows Jesus' popularity.

Mark 2:1-12

This controversy story is also a miracle story, which links it to the previous collection ([1:21-45](#)).

Mark 2:1-3.6

Five controversy stories ([2:1-12](#), [13-17](#), [18-22](#), [23-28](#); [3:1-6](#)), grouped by their common theme, reveal Jesus' great authority and the leaders' hostility toward him.

Mark 2:4

because of the crowd: See [2:1](#). • The roof would have been flat, constructed of mud, thatch, and branches. They literally dug a hole to make an opening.

Mark 2:5

Jesus saw the faith of the paralytic and the four men who brought him. • your sins are forgiven: Those

listening understood Jesus' words as a claim to divine authority ([2:6-10](#); [Luke 7:48-49](#)).

Mark 2:6-7

Only God can forgive sins, yet Jesus had authority to do so ([2:10](#)).

Mark 2:9-11

It is easier to say . . . your sins are forgiven because this claim cannot be directly proved or disproved, while the claim to heal can be. Jesus showed his ability to heal in order to show his authority to forgive.

Mark 2:12

We've never seen anything like this before! Mark consistently records Jesus creating amazement ([1:22](#), [27](#); [4:41](#); [6:50-51](#)).

Mark 2:13-15

Levi was also called Matthew (cp. [Matt 9:9-10](#)). Certain people are known by two names in the New Testament (e.g., Simon=Peter; Saul=Paul; Judas son of James=Thaddaeus, see study note on Mark 3:18). • This kind of tax collector (Greek *telōnēs*) collected sales taxes, customs, and road tolls, in contrast with those who collected the poll tax ([12:14](#)). Local tax collectors like Levi were hated by other Jews because they often gouged the public ([Luke 19:8](#)), and as agents of the Romans, they were regarded as traitors. Jesus invited Levi, a tax collector, to follow him, joining Peter, Andrew, James, and John ([Mark 1:16-20](#)).

Mark 2:13-17

This controversy centers on Jesus' befriending disreputable sinners such as tax collectors and eating with them.

Mark 2:16

The teachers of religious law who were Pharisees understood Jesus' act of eating with sinners as intentionally accepting them as friends ([Luke 15:1-2](#); [19:5, 7](#); [Acts 11:2-18](#); [Gal 2:11-12](#)). Jesus indicated that these tax collectors and sinners were invited to share in the Kingdom of God. In Jesus' ministry, even Gentiles were invited to share the Kingdom ([Mark 5:1-20](#); [7:24-30](#); cp. [Matt 8:5-13](#); [Luke 7:1-10](#); [John 4:43-54](#)).

Mark 2:17

Jesus answered his opponents with a well-known proverb, comparing himself to a doctor and sinners to sick people. Salvation is for those who know they are sinners, not those who think they are righteous ([Luke 16:15](#); [18:9](#); [Rom 3:23](#)).

Mark 2:18-22

This controversy deals with fasting, which Jesus did not practice with his disciples. The Pharisees regularly fasted two days a week, on Mondays and Thursdays ([Luke 18:12](#)), and Jews often fasted when mourning or specially seeking the Lord's favor ([Lev 16:29-31](#); [1 Sam 31:13](#); [2 Sam 1:12](#); [12:21-23](#); [Ezra 8:23](#); [Esth 4:3](#); [Matt 6:16](#)).

Mark 2:19-20

Jesus was like a groom at his wedding, so fasting was inappropriate. It was a time for celebration ([Luke 15:23-25, 32](#)). The disciples would fast when Jesus was taken away by death (see [Acts 13:2-3](#); [14:23](#)).

Mark 2:21-22

Old customs of the old covenant are incompatible with the new arrival of God's Kingdom. Common experience shows that an unshrunk new patch sewn on old clothing will tear the old cloth as it shrinks. Similarly, brittle old wineskins will burst when new wine ferments in them. Jesus' meaning was that the fasting of the old cannot mix with the feasting of the new.

Mark 2:23-28

In this controversy, Jesus and his disciples are accused of breaking the Sabbath ([Exod 20:8-11](#)). Picking grain by hand in another person's field was lawful ([Deut 23:25](#)). The charge was that by rubbing the chaff from the kernels, the disciples were working on the Sabbath, which was forbidden ([Exod 34:21](#)).

Mark 2:25-26

Jesus countered with reference to an incident in the life of King David ([1 Sam 21](#)). When David and his followers ate the sacred loaves—the twelve loaves in the Tabernacle that only priests were allowed to eat—they broke the law (see [Lev 24:5-9](#)). But deeper principles were at work ([Mark 2:27-28](#)).

Mark 2:27-28

Since Jesus is the Lord of humanity ([1 Cor 15:25-28](#); [Eph 1:20-22](#); [Phil 2:9-11](#)) and since the Sabbath was made to meet the needs of people, he is Lord ... over the Sabbath. As with Jesus' authority to forgive sins ([Mark 2:7](#)), this was a claim to divine authority.

Mark 3:1-2

The scene again involves a synagogue, probably in Capernaum ([1:21, 29](#)). The presence of a crippled man on the Sabbath ([3:1-2](#)) created a situation that Jesus' enemies wished to exploit if he healed the man's hand, so they watched him closely.

Mark 3:1-6

This account concludes the collection of controversy stories ([2:1-3:6](#)). As in the preceding story, Jesus is in conflict with the Pharisees over the Sabbath; as with the first story, the controversy involves a healing ([2:1-12](#)).

Mark 3:3-4

Jesus challenged his enemies' view that doing good deeds was forbidden on the Sabbath (cp. [Luke 13:10-17](#)). • To destroy ... life may refer to an

incident in which the Maccabees decided to fight if attacked on the Sabbath (*1 Maccabees* 2:32-41). These great Jewish heroes were willing to kill on the Sabbath, yet the Pharisees would not allow good deeds on the Sabbath. Jesus' question shamed them into silence but did not change their hearts ([Mark 3:5](#)).

Mark 3:5-6

Jesus' opponents' hard hearts would not listen to sound reason, so instead of having changed attitudes, they began to plot how to kill him (see also [11:18](#); [12:12](#); [14:1-2](#), [10-11](#)).

Mark 3:7-12

Jesus' departure to the lake (the Sea of Galilee) sets the scene for [4:1-5:43](#). The multitude that came to see John the Baptist ([1:7](#)) was surpassed by the multitude that came to see Jesus. • Idumea was a region in southern Judea that had been occupied by the Edomites after the Exile. • Tyre and Sidon were Phoenician cities on the Mediterranean coast that Jesus later visited ([7:24](#), [31](#)).

Mark 3:9

The boat probably belonged to Peter and Andrew or to James and John. The crowd's desire to see Jesus was so great that he needed to escape the crush of people ([4:1](#); [5:24](#), [31](#)).

Mark 3:10

Jesus healed many people that day; perhaps he healed all the sick (cp. [Matt 12:15](#)).

Mark 3:11-12

The evil spirits knew who Jesus was ([1:34](#); see also [1:22](#); [5:7](#)), but Jesus did not want his identity revealed.

Mark 3:13-19

The scene now changes to a mountain, and Mark tells how Jesus called his disciples, which is reminiscent of God's call of Old Testament prophets ([Exod 3:14-22](#); [1 Sam 3:4-14](#); [Jer 1:5-19](#)).

Mark 3:14-15

Jesus appointed twelve to represent Israel's twelve tribes and to proclaim that the Kingdom of God had arrived. He called them apostles (Greek *apostoloi*, "emissaries"). He chose them to accompany him and to be sent out (Greek *apostellō*) to preach and to cast out demons. They represented Jesus and were endowed with his authority.

Mark 3:16-18

Simon and Andrew were brothers, as were James and John ([1:16-20](#)). • Peter is the Greek equivalent of the Aramaic *kepa'*, meaning "rock."

Mark 3:17

but Jesus nicknamed them "Sons of Thunder": This nickname probably speaks of their character (cp. [Luke 9:53-54](#)).

Mark 3:18

Philip is fifth on all four lists of the twelve disciples ([Matt 10:1-4](#); [Luke 6:12-16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)); James the son of Alphaeus (not the son of Zebedee and brother of John) is always ninth. Bartholomew might be Nathanael ([John 1:43-51](#)), and Matthew is probably Levi, the tax collector ([Mark 2:14](#); [Matt 9:9](#)). Although Thomas is referred to as "the twin" ([John 11:16](#); [20:24](#); [21:2](#)), nothing else is said in the New Testament about this. Thaddaeus ([Matt 10:3](#)) is missing from Luke's list; he might be Judas, the son of James ([Luke 6:16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). That a government official (Matthew) and an anti-government activist (Simon . . . the zealot) were among the twelve apostles testifies to Jesus' ability to change people's hearts and overcome natural antagonism.

Mark 3:19

Identifying Judas as Iscariot suggests that Mark wanted to avoid confusing him with another Judas ([Luke 6:16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). *Iscariot* probably comes from 'ish ("man of") qeriyoth ("Kerioth," a town in Judea). • who later betrayed him: See [Mark 14:10-11](#), [43-46](#).

Mark 3:20

That Jesus and the disciples can't find time to eat emphasizes Jesus' great popularity with the crowds ([3:7-9](#)).

Mark 3:20-35

This story about Jesus and his family ([3:20-21](#) and [31-35](#)) brackets a controversy story about Jesus' exorcisms ([3:22-30](#)); this arrangement identifies Jesus' family with the religious leaders in opposing him.

Mark 3:21

He's out of his mind: Mark does not explain whether the attempt by Jesus' family to seize him was motivated by sincere but misguided concern, or by hostility. Jesus' brothers and sisters were not among his followers until after his resurrection ([3:31-35](#); [John 7:3-5](#); [1 Cor 15:7](#) mentions James, the brother of Jesus, who became a leader of the Jerusalem church, [Acts 15:13-21](#)).

Mark 3:22

The teachers of religious law (see study note on 1:22) from Jerusalem attributed Jesus' apparent madness to his being possessed by Satan (Greek Beelzeboul; see study note on Matt 10:25). Jesus' opponents credited his miracle-working ability to Satan (as in the rabbinic work, *Sanhedrin* 3:43a, where miracle-working is ascribed to sorcery).

Mark 3:23-27

Jesus showed the absurdity of this charge by giving several analogies. Satan would not undo his own work.

Mark 3:27

Jesus provided a better explanation for his ability to cast out demons: Someone stronger than Satan had arrived ([1:7](#)) and was able to loot Satan's house. Jesus, the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#)), was introducing God's Kingdom and rescuing people from Satan's power.

Mark 3:28-30

The phrase I tell you the truth introduces many of Jesus' sayings and gives emphasis to what follows (see also [8:12](#); [9:1](#), [41](#); [10:15](#), [29](#); [11:23](#); [12:43](#); [13:30](#); [14:9](#), [18](#), [25](#), [30](#)). • All sin and blasphemy can be forgiven, but there is a sin with eternal consequences—blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. To blaspheme the Holy Spirit is to attribute the work of God to an evil spirit. Resisting and denouncing the work of God in this way prevents the convicting work of the Spirit that leads to repentance, saving faith in God, and pardon for sin (see study notes on Matt 12:31-32; cp. [Heb 6:4-6](#); [1 Jn 5:16-17](#)).

Mark 3:31-35

Mark resumes from [3:20-21](#). • Your mother and your brothers: Jesus' brothers are commonly understood to have been children born to Joseph and Mary after Jesus' birth (see also [6:3](#); [Matt 1:25](#); [12:46](#); [John 19:26-27](#)); some interpreters instead believe that they were either Joseph's children by an earlier marriage or Jesus' cousins, due to the Roman Catholic belief that Mary was perpetually a virgin.

Mark 3:33-34

In God's Kingdom, one's true relatives are determined not by blood but by a faith relationship (see also [10:29-30](#)).

Mark 3:35

Doing God's will includes repentance from sin, faith in God, and following Jesus ([1:15](#), [18](#), [20](#)).

Mark 4:1

Jesus again uses a boat to avoid the press of the crowd when he is teaching ([3:9](#); [Luke 5:2-3](#)).

Mark 4:1-34

In this section Mark collects a number of Jesus' teaching parables.

Mark 4:2

Parables are often stories ([Luke 15:11-32](#); [18:1-8](#)) but can also be proverbs ([Mark 3:24-25](#); [Luke 4:23](#)), similes and metaphors ([Matt 5:14](#); [10:16](#)), riddles ([Mark 7:15](#); [14:58](#)), comparisons ([Matt 13:33](#); [Luke 15:3-7](#)), examples ([Luke 10:30-35](#); [12:16-21](#)), or allegories ([Mark 4:3-9](#); [12:1-12](#)).

Mark 4:3-9

The collection begins with the longest parable and its interpretation ([4:13-20](#)), focusing on various types of soil as an analogy for various conditions of the human heart.

Mark 4:10

The scene changes from Jesus' teaching a very large crowd from a boat to his being alone with the twelve disciples and . . . others. Their question concerns all the parables ([4:33-34](#)), not just this one.

Mark 4:11-12

Jesus' real followers were permitted to understand the secret of the Kingdom of God—namely, that the Kingdom of God had come ([1:14-15](#)) and that Christ, the Son of God, was in their midst ([1:1](#)). For outsiders, it all seemed like riddles. • Jesus' reply to the disciples' question suggests that the parables were intended to prevent outsiders from understanding them, so that they would be unable to repent and be forgiven. The quotation from [Isa 6:9-10](#) (Greek version) suggests that it was an intentional judgment on the hearers. Jesus' teaching in parables, and the resultant unbelief of outsiders, fulfilled what the Scriptures had

predicted. The sensitive nature of Jesus' teaching about the Kingdom of God (a theme that would have made Roman authorities very uneasy) made teaching in parables useful in defusing this issue.

Mark 4:13

If Jesus' hearers could not understand the parable, they might lack the grace of citizenship in Christ's Kingdom. However, even the insiders required Jesus' explanation.

Mark 4:14-20

The interpretation of the parable of the four soils is allegorical. The farmer represents a preacher of God's word ([4:14](#)). The four types of soil that receive the seed represent different responses to the preaching of the word. The point of this parable and its interpretation is that hearers should be good soil and heed God's word ([4:9](#)). Only those who produce fruit and endure to the end will be saved ([13:13](#); [8:35](#); [Rev 2:10-11](#)).

Mark 4:21

A lamp is lighted to shine and give people light, not to remain hidden. Citizens of the Kingdom are responsible for putting the light of the Good News on a stand ([4:17](#)).

Mark 4:21-25

These sayings are connected with the exhortation to hear ([4:9](#), [23-24](#)) and with the distinction between insiders and outsiders ([4:11-12](#), [24-25](#)). They illustrate what citizens of the Kingdom will do.

Mark 4:22-23

One day the lamp (i.e., Jesus; cp. [John 8:12](#)) will shine his light on everything that is hidden, on every thought and secret action ([Mark 13:26](#); [14:62](#); see [Phil 2:10-11](#)). The time to listen is before this occurs ([Mark 4:9](#)).

Mark 4:24

Those who listen and respond will be given more understanding, but those outside ([4:11-12](#)) will have greater darkness ([2 Cor 3:14-16](#)).

Mark 4:26-29

This parable focuses on the seed and its inevitable growth. • Just as the earth produces the crops on its own, the consummation of God's Kingdom does not depend on human action. • The leaf blade, the heads of wheat, and the ripened grain describe normal stages in a seed's growth.

Mark 4:26-34

Mark now gives additional seed parables (cp. [4:3-20](#)). Their common theme is the secret of the Kingdom of God ([4:11](#)). The parables of the seed growing secretly ([4:26-29](#)) and of the mustard seed ([4:30-32](#)) describe different stages of the seed-growth process. The Kingdom of God is hidden ([4:21](#)), but growth is certain ([4:26-29](#)) and the result will be glorious ([4:32](#)).

Mark 4:29

Harvest time is analogous to the final inauguration of God's Kingdom. A sickle is a frequent symbol of the final judgment ([Jer 50:16](#); [Joel 3:13](#); [Rev 14:14-19](#)).

Mark 4:30-32

Jesus contrasts a very small beginning with a large result. The mustard seed is proverbially small (see [Matt 17:20](#)).

Mark 4:33-34

Mark's summary of this section indicates that [4:3-32](#) is a collection of parables, not a chronological description of Jesus' teaching on a specific day. • Jesus' private explanation of the parables to the disciples shows that they were not outsiders, even though they sometimes lacked understanding (cp. [4:13](#)).

Mark 4:35-41

This passage focuses on the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God. Jesus' authority over natural forces demonstrated his divinity. • the other side: The eastern side of the Sea of Galilee was the region of the Gerasenes ([5:1](#)). • The fact that other boats followed shows Jesus' fame.

Mark 4:35-5.43

The three miracle stories in this section are connected by a shared location (the Sea of Galilee), the presence of the disciples, the use of a boat, and a common theme, Who is this man? ([4:41](#)).

Mark 4:38

Jesus was probably asleep under the stern, using a bag of ballast sand as a pillow. In 1986, a boat dating from Jesus' time was discovered in the mud near the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee. It is 26½ feet long, 7½ feet wide, and 4½ feet deep, with an elevated stern. It could hold up to fifteen people.

Mark 4:39-40

The disciples still lacked faith in Jesus ([4:41](#)), despite their numerous opportunities to experience his power and authority ([1:21-34](#), [40-45](#); [2:1-12](#); [3:1-5](#)).

Mark 4:41

The disciples were absolutely terrified—a frequent response to Jesus in Mark ([5:15](#), [33](#); [6:50](#); [9:32](#); [10:32](#); [11:18](#); [16:8](#)). • Who is this man? Readers already know that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#), [11](#), [24](#); [3:11](#)).

Mark 5:1

The region of the Gerasenes: Textual and geographical problems make the exact location uncertain. Manuscript evidence supports Gerasa, a city in this region located thirty-seven miles southeast of the Sea of Galilee ([5:13](#)). Some

manuscripts read “Gadarenes”; Gadara was five miles southeast of the Sea of Galilee. A few manuscripts read “Gergesenes”; the town of Gergesa was located on a steep bank on the Sea of Galilee’s eastern shore.

Mark 5:1–20

Jesus and the disciples arrived at the other side of the lake, completing the journey begun in [4:35](#). As in [1:21–28](#) and [3:11](#), the demons truly recognized ([1:34](#)) that Jesus was the Son of the Most High God. For the first time in the Gospel of Mark, a Gentile was the recipient of Jesus’ healing ministry (see study note on 5:10–13; cp. [7:24–30](#)).

Mark 5:2–5

Mark focuses on Jesus. The evil spirit had great strength, but Jesus’ authority was even greater ([5:6–13](#)).

Mark 5:6–8

Despite the man’s horrible condition, Jesus’ coming provided him a glimmer of hope; he ran and knelt before Jesus, seeking help. • Son of the Most High God: Evil spirits know Jesus’ true identity ([1:24](#), [34](#); [3:11](#)). • There was no struggle; Jesus was in charge and the evil spirit obeyed the Master. Torture is the final judgment awaiting evil spirits ([Matt 8:29](#); [Luke 8:31](#)).

Mark 5:9

A legion was a Roman military unit of 5,000–6,000 men. Here it describes the presence of many evil spirits.

Mark 5:10–13

The spirits’ persistent begging shows Jesus’ mastery over them. They were permitted to enter a herd of about 2,000 pigs, whose presence marks this as Gentile territory. Some have focused on the economic loss of the pigs or have speculated about why Jesus let the demons destroy them, but Mark and his readers were interested in how Jesus saved the man.

Mark 5:15–16

The contrast between the former and present condition of the man who had been possessed was a testimony of Jesus’ saving power.

Mark 5:17

The frightened people asked Jesus to go away. Fear and amazement are frequent responses to the mighty acts of Jesus (cp. [1:22](#), [27](#); [2:12](#); [4:41](#); [6:50–51](#)). The response to Jesus’ saving work varied (cp. [4:14–20](#)).

Mark 5:18

Unlike his neighbors ([5:17](#)), the man experienced God’s grace and wanted to go with him (literally *to be with him*; see [3:14](#)).

Mark 5:19–20

Jesus’ mission for the man was to tell others the great things the Lord had done for him. Mark thus identifies Jesus as the Lord. • tell them everything: Unlike other occasions, Jesus did not try to keep his identity secret (see [3:11–12](#)), perhaps because it was less dangerous in this Gentile area. • Ten Towns: See study note on Matt 4:24–25.

Mark 5:21–22

As Jesus arrived in Galilee on the other (i.e., west) side of the lake, . . . a leader of the local synagogue named Jairus approached him. Jairus organized the worship services at the synagogue (cp. [Acts 13:15](#)) and represented the Jewish community to the outside world.

Mark 5:21–43

Two healing miracles are connected by the need for faith ([5:34](#), [36](#)). The story of Jairus’s daughter brackets the story of the healing of the woman who had constant bleeding ([5:25–34](#); see Mark Book Introduction, “Literary Features”), during which Jairus’s sick daughter died ([5:35–43](#)).

Mark 5:23

The father wanted Jesus to heal her physically (*literally that she might be saved*; see [3:4](#); [5:28](#), [34](#); [6:56](#); [10:52](#); [15:30-31](#)).

Mark 5:24-34

As Jesus goes to Jairus's home with a great crowd following, Mark introduces a woman in the crowd who suffered from constant bleeding. This condition not only brought poor health, but made her ceremonially unclean and thus unable to participate in the normal life of the community (see [Lev 15:25-27](#)). She was a model of the kind of faith that Jairus should have.

Mark 5:27-29

The woman's faith ([5:34](#)) convinced her that just touching Jesus' clothing would bring healing; this took place immediately.

Mark 5:33-34

The woman responded in fear—not from guilt, but from the realization that she had experienced a mighty miracle from God. Unlike the fear of the Gerasenes ([5:15-17](#)), her fear was positive and brought Jesus' blessing. She experienced God's grace and salvation.

Mark 5:35-43

Since Jairus had left home, his daughter had died. Jesus reassured Jairus that, despite the death of his daughter and the seeming hopelessness of the situation, Jairus should not be afraid but have faith in Jesus.

Mark 5:36

Just have faith: As the woman had ([5:28](#)).

Mark 5:37

Peter, James, and John became Jesus' inner circle (see [3:16-17](#); [9:2](#); [14:33](#)).

Mark 5:38

The commotion and weeping and wailing confirmed the report of the messengers and dramatized the hopelessness of the situation. Such outbursts of grief were typical of funerals in Jesus' day, where professional mourners were often hired (cp. [Matt 9:23](#)).

Mark 5:39

Sleep is a metaphor for death ([John 11:11](#); [1 Thes 4:13-15](#)). The child isn't dead because she will be resurrected—she's only asleep and will shortly "wake up" and resume her life. The same Greek word translated here as "sleep" refers to death in [Matt 27:52](#); [Acts 7:60](#); [13:36](#); [1 Cor 15:6](#), [18](#), [20](#), [51](#); [1 Thes 4:13-15](#).

Mark 5:40

Because the crowd did not understand Jesus' words, they laughed at him, knowing that the girl had died. He made them all leave, probably to keep them from discouraging the parents any further.

Mark 5:41

Mark translates *Talitha kum* for his Greek-speaking readers as *Little girl, get up!* The Aramaic terms are not magical; they are simply the actual words Jesus spoke when he raised the little girl, since Aramaic was his native language. The Aramaic terms that Mark records probably come from learning the story in Aramaic in Jerusalem.

Mark 5:42

Jesus' authority over death was demonstrated when the little girl immediately stood up and walked around, with no need for recuperation. The transformation was instant and absolute.

Mark 5:43

The miracle is followed by a command not to tell anyone what had happened (see [3:11-12](#)). • give her something to eat: The Lord of nature, demons, illness, and death is also concerned with the daily needs of his creatures.

Mark 6:1-2

The people's amazement at Jesus' teaching was due to the wisdom of his teaching and his power to heal and cast out demons. • Where did he get: His quiet years in Nazareth had not prepared them to accept him as an authoritative teacher and healer.

Mark 6:1-6

Nazareth's rejection of Jesus contrasts ironically with the faith displayed by others, and the miracles he couldn't do contrasts with the power displayed elsewhere.

Mark 6:3-4

The residents of Nazareth thought of Jesus only as a carpenter (literally *craftsman*). • He's just a carpenter, the son of Mary: One expects "son of Joseph"; this phrasing probably indicates that Joseph had died by this time. • brother . . . his sisters: See study note on 3:31-35. • They were deeply offended: They thought Jesus was claiming to be someone he could not possibly be.

Mark 6:5-6

Faith and healing are frequently connected in Mark ([2:5](#); [5:34](#), [36](#); [9:23-24](#); [10:52](#)). Jesus' miracles were not performances but the partial realization of God's Kingdom; entrance to that Kingdom and its benefits require repentance and faith ([1:15](#)). • A few sick people were healed, but the unbelief that Jesus encountered in his own village amazed him, a unique occurrence. • This section of Mark ([3:7-6:6a](#)) speaks of Jesus' rejection by his family ([3:21, 31-35](#)), the scribes ([3:22](#)), and the people of Gerasa ([5:17](#)); it ends with rejection by people in his hometown ([6:1-6a](#)). Along the way, a few people believed and were healed. This ending is similar to the ending of the previous section ([1:14-3:6](#)).

Mark 6:6

This summary of Jesus' healing and preaching ministry introduces an account concerning the disciples. Jesus' teaching from village to village probably took place around the Sea of Galilee and perhaps in Capernaum (see [2:1](#)).

Mark 6:6-8.21

Jesus' mission and the disciples' misunderstanding are prominent themes in this section.

Mark 6:7

two by two: This practice fulfilled the Old Testament requirement of two witnesses ([Num 35:30](#); [Deut 17:6](#); [19:15](#); see [Matt 18:16](#)) and provided for companionship and mutual help ([Acts 13:1-3](#); [15:22](#), [39](#), [40](#)). • giving them authority: Jesus can delegate his authority (see [Mark 1:27](#); [2:10](#)) to others. • The disciples were to cast out evil spirits and to preach and heal ([6:12-13](#); see [6:30](#)).

Mark 6:7-13

Jesus now sent the disciples out to preach and heal. During this mission, Jesus' memorable teachings were engraved in their minds by retelling, and it prepared them to remember and retell later what Jesus did and taught ([Luke 1:2](#)).

Mark 6:8-9

The instructions for the disciples' mission were about what they should leave behind (food . . . bag . . . money . . . change of clothes). They were to travel light, counting on Jewish hospitality for food and lodging (cp. [Luke 22:35-37](#)).

Mark 6:10

They were to stay in the same house and not abuse hospitality by seeking out better offers of food and lodging.

Mark 6:11

The shaking of dust from the feet is best interpreted as a symbolic act pronouncing God's judgment upon those who rejected the apostles' preaching (cp. [Acts 18:6](#)), which was really a rejection of Jesus and of God, who sent him ([9:37](#)).

Mark 6:12-13

The message to repent is an abbreviation of the fuller message of [1:15](#).

Mark 6:14

soon heard about Jesus: The successful mission in Galilee and Perea of six teams of disciples ([6:12-13](#)) spread Jesus' fame throughout the region. • This must be John the Baptist raised from the dead: Either Herod was thinking that the spirit of John the Baptist had come to rest upon Jesus at his death, as the spirit of Elijah came upon Elisha, or he was saying figuratively in exasperation, "This is John the Baptist all over again!"

Mark 6:14-29

The account of John the Baptist's death, sandwiched between the sending out and the return of the disciples, continues the theme of Jesus' authority and power (see [6:7, 14](#)). John's fate and the warning given to the disciples in their missionary charge ([6:11](#)) also foreshadowed Jesus' death. The one greater even than John ([1:8](#)) would soon be handed over to religious and political leaders and put to death ([8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:33](#)).

Mark 6:15

The return of the prophet Elijah had been prophesied in [Mal 3:1](#); [4:5-6](#) (cp. [Mark 9:11-13](#)).

Mark 6:17

imprison John: The Jewish historian Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.2) says that John was imprisoned in the fortress of Machaerus in Perea. • Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.1-4) states that Herodias was the wife of Herod Antipas's half brother, Herod Philip.

Mark 6:18

Mark gives the moral-religious reason for the imprisonment and execution of John the Baptist. Josephus refers to the political reason (fear that John's great popularity might start a revolution; Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.2). Similarly, the religious reasons for Jesus' condemnation ([Mark 14:63-64](#)) became political when he was brought before Pontius Pilate ([15:2](#); [Luke 23:2-3](#)). • It is against God's law: Not only was the relationship adulterous ([Lev 20:10](#)), but it violated the further law against marrying a brother's wife ([Lev 18:16; 20:21](#)).

Mark 6:19-28

Herodias's role in the murder of John the Baptist recalls the story of Jezebel ([1 Kgs 19:1-2](#)). Herod succumbed to pressure ([Mark 6:26-28](#)), which foreshadows the later story of Pontius Pilate, who put Jesus to death against his better judgment (cp. [6:20, 25-28](#) with [15:6-15](#)).

Mark 6:22

his daughter, also named Herodias: According to the first-century Jewish historian Josephus, Herodias's daughter was also named Salome (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.4).

Mark 6:29

This verse is similar to the description of Jesus' death and burial (see [15:43-46](#)). Disciples of John existed after his death until at least the AD 200s (see [Acts 18:24-19:7](#)).

Mark 6:30

Mark calls Jesus' disciples apostles here to indicate their new status as those who had been sent out (see study note on [3:14-15](#)) and to avoid possible confusion between them and John the Baptist's disciples. • The apostles reported the success of what they had done and taught.

Mark 6:30-44

The disciples' mission concludes ([6:6-13](#), [30-34](#)), followed by the account of the feeding of the 5,000 ([6:35-44](#); see also [Matt 14:13-21](#); [Luke 9:10-17](#); [John 6:1-15](#)). The feeding of the 4,000 is sufficiently different to indicate that these were two separate occasions (see [Mark 8:1-10](#)).

Mark 6:31-33

Let's go: Jesus and the disciples probably proceeded northward along the western shore of the Sea of Galilee toward Bethsaida ([Luke 9:10](#)), in sight of the crowds along the shore. • so many people: The great crowds demonstrate the success of the apostolic mission and the greatness of Jesus, whom the apostles represented.

Mark 6:34

they were like sheep without a shepherd: God's people need a shepherd ([Num 27:16-17](#); [1 Kgs 22:17](#); [2 Chr 18:16](#); see [Jer 13:10](#); [Ezek 34:23](#)). Teaching people God's word is compared to feeding sheep in Jewish literature (e.g., [Ezek 34:1-24](#); [2 Baruch 77:13-15](#)).

Mark 6:35-36

The place where Jesus taught was remote,, but it still had farms and villages . . . nearby where the people could buy something to eat.

Mark 6:37

Jesus suggests that, just as the disciples were able to cast out demons and heal through his power ([6:7](#), [13](#), [30](#)), they should be able to feed the crowd. Their reply considered only what they themselves were capable of doing. They did not consider Jesus' power.

Mark 6:41

The words took, blessed, breaking, and giving echo Jesus' words at the Last Supper ([14:22-25](#)). Both events envision the final messianic banquet in which believers will eat and drink with Jesus in the

Kingdom of God ([14:25](#); [Matt 5:6](#); [22:1-10](#); see [Rev 2:7](#); [19:7-9](#); [22:1-2](#), [14](#), [17-19](#)).

Mark 6:42-44

This miracle makes Elisha's great miracle of feeding 100 people with twenty loaves ([2 Kgs 4:42-44](#)) seem trivial by comparison. Readers of the Gospel must ask themselves, "Who is this man who does such things?" ([Mark 4:41](#)). He is the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#)).

Mark 6:45-46

The disciples proceeded to Bethsaida, the home of Peter and Andrew ([John 1:44](#)), while Jesus dismissed the crowd and went apart to pray. Jesus was a man of prayer ([Mark 1:35](#)) and urged his disciples to pray (see [14:38](#)).

Mark 6:45-52

This story is a manifestation of Jesus' glory to the disciples ([6:48-50](#)). It is also a rescue story ([6:47-48](#), [51](#)) and a story about the disciples' lack of understanding ([6:51-52](#)).

Mark 6:48

It was about three o'clock in the morning (literally *about the fourth watch of the night*, which began at 3:00 am): This was a Roman designation of time (Jews reckoned only three watches), which supports the view that Mark wrote for Christians in Rome. • Mark does not explain how Jesus saw his disciples' plight late at night in the middle of the lake (cp. [John 6:19](#)), as it is not important to the story. • Jesus came toward them, walking on the water: It appears that Jesus' purpose was to rescue the disciples from the storm. However, Mark then states that Jesus intended to go past them. Numerous attempts have been made to explain this, but the best explanation is that "to go past them" speaks of a divine manifestation (cp. [Exod 33:18-34:6](#); [1 Kgs 19:11-13](#)): Jesus apparently sought to show his divine glory to the disciples. This understanding is supported by the disciples' fear, a response often associated with theophany. • Many have tried to rationalize the miracle of Jesus' walking on the sea, but Mark, Matthew, and John

clearly understood this as a miracle, beyond natural explanation. If Jesus is in fact the Son of God, there is no need to find another explanation.

Mark 6:49–50

The disciples' terror is understandable—humans cannot walk on water, so they concluded that they were seeing a ghost. As in many divine manifestations, the Lord gave a word of assurance: Don't be afraid and Take courage! The reason is, I am here! It was not a ghost but Jesus—their friend, Savior, and Lord. • I am here!: Because Jesus' walking on the sea and stilling the storm were miraculous, Mark's original readers would have understood the exclamation I am as a parallel to God's self-description in the Old Testament ([Exod 3:14](#); [Deut 32:39](#); [Isa 41:4](#); [43:10–13](#)) and thus as a reference to Jesus' divinity.

Mark 6:51

Jesus' entrance into the boat calmed the storm. • totally amazed: They were reverential and awed at the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God (cp. [2:12](#); [5:24](#); [Matt 14:33](#)).

Mark 6:52

The account ends with a comment about the disciples' dullness. It was not from lack of opportunity to believe in Jesus—they had witnessed the miracle of the loaves and many other miracles—but because their hearts were too hard, usually a quality of Jesus' opponents (e.g., [3:5](#); see also [8:17](#), [21](#); [9:32](#)). Later their hearts would be softened, and they would understand ([Luke 24:44–49](#); [John 12:16](#); [13:7](#)).

Mark 6:53

Gennesaret refers to a fertile plain, 3.5 miles long by 0.5 miles wide (5.6 by 0.8 kilometers), between Tiberias and Capernaum on the northwest coast of the Sea of Galilee. The original journey was to Bethsaida ([6:45](#)), so perhaps the winds ([6:48](#)) blew the ship off course and they landed at Gennesaret. Alternatively, [6:45](#) might indicate the direction of the journey (i.e., northeast) and not the actual goal of the voyage.

Mark 6:53–56

This summary of Jesus' ministry in Galilee emphasizes his great popularity and healing ability.

Mark 6:56

The fringe of a garment refers to the tassels worn by Jewish men on their robes (see [Num 15:38–39](#); [Deut 22:12](#)). Just touching the fringe of the garment of Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God, brought healing to the sick (see also [Mark 3:10](#); [5:28](#)).

Mark 7:1

Readers already know that the Pharisees and teachers of religious law were hostile to Jesus (see [2:16](#), [24](#); [3:6](#), [22](#)).

Mark 7:1–23

This account has no direct connection with what precedes it. It assumes only a context such as "Once in the ministry of Jesus." After setting the scene ([7:1–4](#)), Mark introduces the Pharisees' question ([7:5](#)), followed by Jesus' response ([7:6–23](#)). The first part of Jesus' response ([7:6–13](#)) centers around two Old Testament passages and a twofold attack on the Pharisees' traditions ([7:6–8](#), [9–13](#)). In the second part ([7:14–23](#)), Jesus teaches about what does and does not truly defile.

Mark 7:2–4

Mark explains the Pharisaic practices of ritual cleansing for his non-Jewish (Gentile) readers. The ancient traditions (literally *the traditions of the elders*) were as yet unwritten accounts that the Pharisees believed had been given to Moses on Mount Sinai along with the written law. They were written down around AD 200 in the Mishnah, one of the key sources for understanding ancient Judaism.

Mark 7:5

Since the Pharisees believed that their oral traditions were given to Moses as part of God's divine revelation, they asked Jesus why his disciples did not keep them. After all, teachers were responsible for the behavior of their disciples (see [2:24](#)).

Mark 7:6–8

Jesus first responds by quoting [Isa 29:13](#) (Greek version), which deals with the farce of equating man-made ideas with God's commands. It describes well the situation in which the Pharisees had substituted their human tradition for God's law.

Mark 7:9–13

Next, Jesus provides an instance where the Pharisees' traditions contradicted God's law and allowed them to sidestep its requirements.

Mark 7:11–12

But you say: The contrast with God's law is emphatic—their tradition repudiated God's command for people to honor their parents by providing for their needs. • 'For I have vowed to give to God what I would have given to you': The tradition said that people could sidestep their obligation to support their parents by dedicating some of their resources to God, thus disregarding and dishonoring their needy parents.

Mark 7:13

The result of such traditions was to cancel the word of God. • only one example among many others: It was not an isolated instance; see, e.g., [Isa 1:10–20](#); [58:1–14](#).

Mark 7:14–23

Jesus' second argument against the Pharisees was a proverb that Jesus told the crowd. Later, in the privacy of a home, Jesus explained it to his disciples ([7:17–23](#)). It concerns moral distinctions about

eating. Eating affects the digestive system, but moral issues involve the heart. The heart is a metaphor for the seat of moral decision making. How a person eats (with clean or unclean hands) or what a person eats (clean or unclean food) affects only the digestive tract, so it has no bearing on the moral issues of the soul. To help his later readers understand the implications of Jesus' teaching, Mark adds the interpretive comment By saying this, he declared that every kind of food is acceptable in God's eyes. In the apostolic church, Peter and Paul were instrumental in bringing this implication to light (see [Acts 10:1–11:18](#); [Rom 14:14](#); [1 Cor 8:8](#); [Gal 2:11–21](#)).

Mark 7:20–22

These verses summarize thirteen things that truly defile a person. These actions and vices all come from the heart.

Mark 7:24

The city of Tyre and its surrounding regions lie on the Mediterranean coast in modern-day Lebanon. Originally an island, Tyre became a peninsula when Alexander the Great constructed a half-mile ramp from the mainland in 332 BC. Tyre had one of the most important harbors on the eastern side of the Mediterranean Sea. People earlier had come from Tyre to hear Jesus and see him work miracles ([3:7–8](#)), which explains how the Tyrian woman knew of him. • There is much discussion about why Jesus left Galilee to visit this Gentile region. Mark provides no explanation, so any suggestion is pure speculation. Mark's Gentile readers, however, would have understood this journey by Jesus as foreshadowing the church's mission to the Gentile world that led to their own conversion (for more about the genesis of the church in Rome, see Romans Book Introduction).

Mark 7:24–30

The discussion of clean and unclean and of undefiled and defiled in [7:1–23](#) has prepared readers for the story of the Gentile woman's faith. For Jews, Gentiles were defiled by definition, because they did not keep the regulations of the Torah (see [Acts 10:1–11:18](#), especially [10:14–15](#); [11:2–3](#), [8–9](#)).

Mark 7:25–26

The woman was from Syrian Phoenicia and therefore a Gentile. The urgency and intensity of the woman's petition is seen in her falling at Jesus' feet and begging.

Mark 7:27–28

Jesus' reply to the woman seems like a harsh refusal, but their interaction indicates that he wanted to see her faith (cp. [Matt 15:28](#)). • Jesus' use of first did not exclude her as a Gentile from the grace of God but indicated that his mission was first to the Jews ([Acts 13:46](#); [Rom 1:16](#)). The woman responded to Jesus' words with humility and faith. She acknowledged the priority of the Jewish people but argued that there was more than enough food for the dogs as well. (In Jewish literature, Gentiles were frequently referred to as dogs, which were seen as filthy scavengers rather than as adorable pets; see also study note on Rev 22:15.) The woman's persistence and acknowledgment of Jesus as Lord were rewarded.

Mark 7:29–30

For similar healings from a distance, see [Matt 8:5–13](#) // [Luke 7:1–10](#) and [John 4:46–54](#).

Mark 7:31–37

This miracle is very similar in order and vocabulary to the healing of the blind man in [8:22–26](#). Healing miracles in the Gospels follow a similar pattern—the constant telling and retelling of similar stories probably standardized their form and wording. • This healing miracle includes a change of scene. Although some interpret the next miracle as occurring in the Gentile world (Sidon or Decapolis), it probably took place after Jesus returned to the Sea of Galilee. The next incident takes place there ([8:10](#)) without a change of scene.

Mark 7:33

The healing was performed privately ([7:33](#); see [5:40–43](#); [8:23](#)) to prevent the spread of messianic

fervor (see [3:11–12](#); cp. [John 6:15](#)). • Jesus also used saliva in a healing at [Mark 8:23](#), where he spit on a man's eyes in curing his blindness. The medicinal use of saliva in ancient times is well documented.

Mark 7:34

Since Jesus was looking up to heaven when he sighed, his sigh is probably best understood as a prayerful gesture. • Ephphatha is an Aramaic term that Mark translates for his readers (see also [3:17](#); [5:41](#); [14:36](#); [15:34](#)). These are not magical formulas or incantations; Mark is simply recounting some of the original words Jesus spoke. Matthew and Luke do not seem to have attributed any special significance to the Aramaic words of Jesus, since they did not include them in their Gospels.

Mark 7:36–37

Despite his desire to avoid attention, Jesus' greatness shone too brightly—his person, his teaching, and his ability to heal inspired awe, and he could not be hidden.

Mark 8:1–3

The last reference to a large crowd was at the feeding of the 5,000 ([6:34](#)). Jesus showed compassion in [6:34](#) because the people “were like sheep without a shepherd.” These stories reflect Jesus' concern for the total person—this time especially for the people's hunger. They were in the wilderness ([8:4](#)) and had no food ([8:1](#)). They had been with Jesus for three days and had nothing to eat ([8:2](#)), and they had come a long way and needed to eat before returning home ([8:3](#)).

Mark 8:1–10

The stories about feeding the 4,000 and the 5,000 are similar. All four Gospels report the earlier feeding of the 5,000 ([6:35–44](#); [Matt 14:13–21](#); [Luke 9:10–17](#); [John 6:1–15](#)), but only Mark and Matthew ([Matt 15:32–39](#)) also record the feeding of the 4,000 as a separate miracle ([Mark 8:19–21](#); [Matt 16:9–10](#)). The details of the events are different.

Mark 8:4

The disciples' frustration at the situation reveals their dullness. They knew how God provided manna in the wilderness for his people in Moses' time ([Exod 16](#)). They were now in the presence of one far greater than Moses (see [Mark 9:5-7](#)) and had recently seen him feed a greater number of people in a similar situation ([6:30-44](#)). However, they still did not understand (cp. [6:52](#)). Even so, Jesus worked through them to bring physical and spiritual food to the hungry ([8:6-8](#)). What they could not do by themselves, the mighty Son of God would do through them.

Mark 8:5

Seven loaves: Numerous attempts have been made to allegorize the numbers in the two feeding miracles, but the lack of consensus among these interpretations, and the reference to "a few fish" in the present story, suggest that the numbers are not symbolic. None of the Gospel writers associate any clear significance with these numbers, and this should warn us against doing so. As with the feeding of the 5,000, the purpose of the numbers is to magnify the greatness of the miracle and of Jesus.

Mark 8:6-7

took, thanked God, distributed: These terms foreshadow the Last Supper (cp. [14:22-25](#)).

Mark 8:8

They ate as much as they wanted. Having plenty of food shows the greatness of God's kingdom and the one who brought it.

Mark 8:10-13

- Like the earlier miracle where Jesus fed 5,000 people ([6:30-44](#)), after feeding 4,000 people, Jesus traveled across the Sea of Galilee by boat (compare [6:45](#)). When he arrived, the Pharisees came to argue with him. They demanded that Jesus show them a miracle as proof (compare [7:1-23](#)).
- We do not know where Dalmanutha was located. [Matthew 15:39](#) uses the name *Magadan* instead of *Dalmanutha* when describing this place.

Mark 8:11

The antagonism of the Pharisees was persistent ([2:16-18](#), [24](#); [3:6](#); [7:1-5](#); [10:2](#); [12:13](#), [15](#)). The request for a sign is at times acceptable ([Judg 6:36-40](#); [2 Kgs 20:8-11](#); [Isa 7:10-12](#); see also [John 2:18-19](#)), but in this case it was obstinate testing of God.

- The sought-after sign was not a healing, an exorcism, a raising from the dead, or a nature miracle, for there had been many of these already, and Jesus' ability to work such signs was well known ([Mark 1:32-34](#), [45](#); [3:7-12](#); [6:53-56](#)) even to the Pharisees ([3:22](#)). What they sought was a miraculous sign from heaven—that is, directly from God—that would demonstrate once for all that Jesus was the Christ. No sign, however, could ever convince them of this. For those whose hearts were open to the truth, the miracles that Jesus had already done ([Luke 7:22](#)) were clear and irrefutable signs that Jesus was the Messiah, the Son of God. For those outside ([Mark 4:11-12](#)), no sign could make them believe (cp. [Luke 6:19-31](#)).

Mark 8:12

I tell you the truth: Jesus' response was as strong as an oath meaning, "[May God's judgment fall upon me] if I give this generation any such sign." Such oaths express an unbending commitment (see [Gen 14:22-23](#); [Num 32:10-11](#); [Ruth 1:17](#); [1 Sam 3:17](#); [20:13](#); [2 Sam 3:35](#); [19:13](#)). • Jesus elsewhere describes this generation as "adulterous and sinful" ([Mark 8:38](#)) and "faithless" ([9:19](#)).

Mark 8:14

The reference to having only one loaf of bread reminds readers of recent occasions when the disciples had not had enough bread and Jesus miraculously provided enough bread to feed thousands of people.

Mark 8:14–21

This account of the journey across the Sea of Galilee reflects on Jesus' greatness, as manifested in the two feeding miracles, and emphasizes the dullness of the disciples, who do not see, hear, or understand because of their hardened hearts (see [4:9–20](#); [6:52](#)).

Mark 8:15

Matthew says that the yeast of the Pharisees refers to their false teaching ([Matt 16:12](#)). It could also refer to their unbelief and hardness of heart ([Mark 8:10–13](#)). The reference to Herod could point to his unwillingness to accept what he knew to be true ([6:14](#), [16](#), [20](#)).

Mark 8:16

The disciples completely missed the point of Jesus' warning ([8:15](#)) and forgot that because Jesus was with them, their supply of bread was irrelevant.

Mark 8:17–20

Jesus asked eight questions that rebuked the disciples. They, of all people, should have been aware of the miraculous power of the Son of God. Although the disciples still remembered the feeding miracles, they never considered the implications for their immediate situation.

Mark 8:19–20

Jesus' questions precisely recalled the feeding miracles ([6:30–44](#); [8:1–10](#)).

Mark 8:21

Don't you understand yet? This question implies a time when they would truly understand. Mark's readers knew that Jesus' resurrection would give the disciples understanding of Jesus' identity and power (see, e.g., [Acts 4:23–31](#)).

Mark 8:22–26

Earlier, Jesus and the disciples set out unsuccessfully for Bethsaida ([6:45](#)); here, they arrive, and Jesus heals a blind man. Only Mark has this two-part healing; it might connect with the opening of the disciples' spiritual eyes in the next account ([8:27–38](#)). • [John 1:44](#) identifies Bethsaida as the home of Peter, Andrew, James, and John (see also [John 12:21](#)). This small fishing village, although technically part of Gaulanitis, was generally considered part of Galilee ([John 12:21](#)). It was relocated and given status as a city by Philip the Tetrarch (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.2.1).

Mark 8:23

spitting on the man's eyes: See [7:33](#); cp. [John 9:6–7](#). Attempts to diagnose the man's exact medical condition are speculative and unprofitable, diverting attention from the miracle.

Mark 8:24–25

The healing was not instantaneous—the man saw imperfectly at first. Jesus' second laying on of hands brought complete healing. Who is this man who stills the sea and heals the blind? Peter reveals this in the next account—he is the Messiah ([8:29](#)).

Mark 8:26

The story ends with Jesus telling the healed man to keep the event a secret (see [3:11–12](#)).

Mark 8:27–28

Philip the Tetrarch, son of Herod the Great, built Caesarea Philippi on the slopes of Mount Hermon about twenty-five miles (forty kilometers) north of the Sea of Galilee. The more famous Caesarea on

the coast had been built by Philip's father. • Who do people say I am? As a good teacher, Jesus asked a question to elicit his disciples' understanding. The response is similar to [6:14-16](#). • John the Baptist: See study note on 6:14. • one of the other prophets: Jesus was clearly considered a prophet ([6:4](#); [14:65](#); [Luke 7:16, 39](#); [13:33](#); [24:19](#)).

Mark 8:27-38

Peter's declaration of Jesus as Messiah and Jesus' first prediction of his death mark a turning point in Mark's Gospel and a new stage in Jesus' life. The question, "Who is this man?" raised by the disciples in [4:41](#), is now answered by Peter.

Mark 8:27-9.1

This section is the first cycle containing a prediction by Jesus of his suffering ([8:31](#)), an error by the disciples ([8:32-33](#)), and a collection of Jesus' sayings about discipleship ([8:34-9:1](#)). Cp. [9:30-10:31](#).

Mark 8:29-30

But who do you say I am? In the Greek text, *you* is emphatic. Peter responded for the group, You are the Messiah. Peter's confession was correct, as the command not to tell anyone about him indicates (see [3:11-12](#); see also [1:1](#); [14:61-62](#); [Matt 16:17](#)).

Mark 8:31

It was a divine necessity that Jesus must suffer (see also [9:11](#); [13:7, 10](#)). The immediate cause for Jesus' suffering was the elders, the leading priests, and the teachers of religious law (see [10:33](#); [11:18, 27](#); [14:1, 43, 53](#)), but the ultimate cause was the will of God. • Jesus' death would not be the end, for three days later he would rise from the dead. • Three days later is a synonym for *on the third day* ([Matt 16:21](#); [Luke 9:22](#)) and *after three days and three nights* ([Matt 12:40](#)).

Mark 8:31-38

Then Jesus began to teach the disciples that he would suffer and be killed in Jerusalem and three

days later . . . rise from the dead. Jesus now explicitly predicted what he had revealed in veiled form ([2:19-20](#)). In response, Peter objected, so Jesus taught him and the other disciples the nature of his mission and what it really means to follow him.

Mark 8:32

Peter understood what Jesus had said, but he did not accept it. Peter shared the popular idea that the Messiah was to be a victorious national ruler, so he thought Jesus' talk of suffering and death was nonsense.

Mark 8:33

Jesus looked at his disciples before he publicly rebuked Peter; he wanted them to understand that Peter was wrong. • Get away from me, Satan does not mean that Peter was demon-possessed. Peter spoke from a human point of view, not from God's, so he unwittingly spoke for Satan, the god of this world ([2 Cor 4:4](#)), and repeated Satan's temptation (cp. [Matt 4:8-10](#)).

Mark 8:34-38

Jesus' invitation to his disciples and the crowd lays out the cost of being his follower. • To give up your own way involves letting Jesus determine your goals and purposes in life. To take up your cross is metaphorical (cp. [Luke 9:23](#)); it indicates that faithfulness to Jesus must extend, if required, even to the point of death. To follow Jesus' teaching and example is a continual commitment.

Mark 8:35

If you try to hang on to (literally *save*) your life by keeping it from Jesus, you will lose it in the next world. But if you lose it to Jesus and his cause (the spread of the Good News), you will save it forever.

Mark 8:36-37

The implied answer to Jesus' rhetorical question is that possessing the entire world has no value if you give up eternal life. "He is no fool who gives what

he cannot keep to gain that which he cannot lose” (Jim Elliot). You need your soul to enjoy the benefits of the world to come. When you forfeit your life or soul, there is nothing you can give to purchase it back.

Mark 8:38

When Jesus, as the Son of Man, returns in glory to judge the world, he will be ashamed of those who were ashamed to be identified with him and his message (cp. [Matt 7:21-23](#); [10:32-33](#); [Luke 12:8-9](#); [2 Tim 2:12](#)).

Mark 9:1

The introductory I tell you the truth indicates that the promise in this verse is important, but the meaning of the promise is much debated. It might suggest that some of the disciples will (1) witness Jesus’ resurrection from the dead (ch [16](#)); (2) experience the coming of the Spirit upon the church ([Acts 2](#)); (3) see the fall of Jerusalem in AD 70; or (4) witness Jesus’ transfiguration as a foretaste of God’s coming Kingdom. Mark’s placement of the promise right before the transfiguration account ([Mark 9:2-8](#)) indicates that he probably meant the transfiguration as the fulfillment (see [2 Pet 1:16-18](#)).

Mark 9:2-8

This account is tied to [8:27-9:1](#) both chronologically (six days later) and thematically ([9:7](#)). • The presence of Peter, James, and John (see also [5:37](#); [13:3](#); [14:33](#)) might be the fulfillment of [9:1](#) (“some standing here”). Some interpreters believe that the pre-incarnate glory of the Son of God broke through the veil of his humanity ([John 1:14](#); [17:5](#)) at the transfiguration. It is more likely that this event was an advance glimpse of the Son of Man’s future glory (see [Matt 16:28](#); [2 Pet 1:16-18](#); cp. [Exod 34:28-35](#); [2 Cor 3:7-18](#)).

Mark 9:4

The appearance of Elijah and Moses might indicate the fulfillment of the law and the prophets in Jesus (see [Matt 5:17](#); cp. [Mal 4:4-5](#)).

Mark 9:5-6

The suggestion to build three shelters as memorials (see [Lev 23:33-43](#); [Num 29:12-34](#)) places Moses, Elijah, and Jesus on the same footing. The suggestion ignores Peter’s own earlier confession ([Mark 8:29](#)) and the fact that only Jesus had been transfigured ([9:2-3](#)).

Mark 9:7

a cloud: Cp. [Exod 40:34-35](#). • The voice from the cloud issued a stern rebuke of Peter’s suggestion: This is my dearly loved Son—not an equal of Moses and Elijah. God’s voice also confirmed Peter’s earlier confession ([Mark 8:29](#)), and it indirectly rebuked Peter for rejecting Jesus’ prediction of his suffering ([8:32](#)) by telling him and the other disciples to listen to him.

Mark 9:8

Only Jesus remained, not Moses or Elijah. Jesus was clearly superior to Elijah and Moses.

Mark 9:9

Secrecy would no longer be necessary after the Son of Man had risen from the dead, because Jesus the Messiah would then be clearly understood as apolitical and non-militaristic, so he could be proclaimed openly to all (see [Acts 2:36](#); [3:6](#)).

Mark 9:10

Only after the fact did the three disciples understand what Jesus meant by “rising from the dead.”

Mark 9:11

The disciples wanted to understand the prediction that Elijah must return before the Messiah comes (see [Mal 4:5-6](#)). How did this prediction fit with Jesus’ proclamation of God’s Kingdom and his prediction of his own death, resurrection, and return ([Mark 8:31](#), [38](#); [9:9](#))?

Mark 9:12

The teachers of the law were correct: Elijah must return before the consummation of God's Kingdom, but Scripture also said that the Son of Man would suffer greatly (e.g., [Ps 22](#); [Isa 52:13–53:12](#)).

Mark 9:13

The teachers of the law erred by not realizing that Elijah had already come (see [Matt 17:11–13](#); cp. [Mal 4:5–6](#)). As a result, they failed to recognize that the Kingdom of God had already come and that the Messiah's suffering and death that were predicted in Scripture were about to take place.

Mark 9:14

Jesus and the three disciples (Peter, James, and John) rejoined the other disciples, the crowd, and the teachers of the law. This account is similar to the story of Moses descending from Mount Sinai to rejoin the people of Israel ([Exod 34:29–35](#)).

Mark 9:14–29

This is the fourth and last exorcism in Mark ([1:21–28](#); [5:1–20](#); [7:24–30](#)). The disciples were unable to perform the exorcism, so Jesus performed it, emphasizing the necessity of faith (cp. [2:5](#); [5:34](#); [10:52](#)). This is another example of Jesus' great healing ability and of the disciples' failure ([8:32–33](#); [9:5–7](#)).

Mark 9:15

Some have suggested that just as Moses reflected God's glory when he descended from the mountain, Jesus' glorious transfiguration was still evident, so the crowds responded with awe. It is equally possible that Jesus' arrival after being absent was enough to elicit the awe of the crowd.

Mark 9:18

These symptoms are often associated with epilepsy (see [Matt 17:15](#)), but Mark emphasizes the

demonic origin of the child's problem ([Mark 9:17–18](#), [25–26](#), [28](#)). The disciples' inability to heal the child magnifies the effect of Jesus' power ([9:25–26](#)).

Mark 9:19

Jesus said to them: Jesus might have been speaking to the disciples, the father ([9:22–24](#)), the crowd, or all present. • How long? Their lack of faith was obstinate and hard-hearted (cp. [3:5](#); [6:52](#); [8:17](#); [10:5](#)).

Mark 9:20

The demon's reaction was nonverbal (contrast [1:24](#); [5:7](#), [9–10](#); see also [1:34](#); [3:11–12](#)) but violent, as the father had described ([9:18](#)).

Mark 9:21–22

The demon's activity had been taking place since he was a little boy, and the demon had tried to kill the child in various ways. • if you can: The father's request indicates that his faith had been severely dampened ([9:18](#)).

Mark 9:23

Jesus challenged the man to believe in the power of God—Anything is possible if a person believes (see [11:22–24](#)), while lack of faith can hinder God's saving activity (see [6:5](#)).

Mark 9:24

In desperation, the father cried out that he believed, though weakly.

Mark 9:25

The crowd was approaching, so Jesus quickly proceeded with the exorcism. • The I in the command to the demon is emphatic, dramatizing Jesus' authority and power. • never enter him again! At times exorcisms could be temporary (see [Matt 12:43–45](#); [Luke 11:24–26](#)).

Mark 9:26-27

The demon's violent reaction revealed its strength and showed Jesus' greatness (cp. [1:25-26](#); [5:15](#)).

Mark 9:28-29

The account ends, surprisingly, by stressing the importance of prayer rather than of faith (cp. [11:22-24](#)).

Mark 9:30-10.31

This section is the second cycle (see study note on 8:27-9:1) containing a prediction about Jesus' suffering ([9:30-32](#)), an error by the disciples ([9:33-34](#)), and teaching about discipleship ([9:35-10:31](#)).

Mark 9:31

Jesus continued to seek privacy (see [7:24](#)) for teaching the disciples about his coming suffering. • The Son of Man is going to be betrayed: See [14:10-11](#), [41-45](#).

Mark 9:32

The disciples were still unable to accept Jesus' teaching concerning his death or to recognize how it fit into God's plan.

Mark 9:33-34

Capernaum was Jesus' home in Galilee ([1:21](#); [2:1](#)). • Jesus' disciples didn't answer his question because they knew that he would disapprove of their discussion. • about which of them was the greatest: This issue would come up again in [10:35-37](#).

Mark 9:33-50

Because the disciples did not understand Jesus' prediction of his suffering, they were unable to see its implications for their own lives.

Mark 9:35

Jesus sat down, assuming the role of a teacher (see [4:1-2](#); [12:41](#); [Matt 5:1](#); [Luke 4:20](#); [5:3](#)). True greatness in God's Kingdom involves being the servant of everyone else, not the master, as Jesus would make clear by his own example in [Mark 10:45](#).

Mark 9:36-37

In Jesus' day, children were not romanticized as innocent and pure but were considered to be weak and inferior. Children were to be received on my behalf. Welcoming a child is an example of humbly taking the last place and serving everyone else ([9:35](#); cp. [10:13-16](#)). Other sayings about receiving or rejecting Jesus also involve receiving or rejecting his followers ([Matt 10:40](#); [25:31-46](#); [Luke 10:16](#); [John 13:20](#)).

Mark 9:38-41

An unknown exorcist was casting out demons in Jesus' name though he was not one of the twelve disciples ([9:38-40](#)). John objected, but Jesus corrected him. • we told him to stop: Cp. [10:35-43](#); [Luke 9:51-55](#). • The success of the unknown exorcist is contrasted with the failure of the disciples in the previous account ([Mark 9:14-29](#)).

Mark 9:40

The negative parallel to this proverb is found in [Luke 11:23](#). These two proverbs should be understood as complementary, not contradictory, for Luke includes them both ([Luke 9:50](#); [11:23](#)). The exorcist casting out demons in Jesus' name was not against Jesus, but for him.

Mark 9:42-50

if you cause . . . sin: The consequences of causing sin ties these verses together ([9:42-43](#), [45](#), [47](#)). These sayings were not meant to be interpreted literally, for carrying them out would not prevent sin (see [Matt 15:10-20](#)). What Jesus conveys by these warnings is that no sin is worth going to hell for. It

is better to repent—even if repenting is as painful as cutting off a hand, foot, or eye—than to suffer the punishment of hell.

Mark 9:43

hell: Greek *Gehenna*, referring to the Valley of Hinnom, which bordered Jerusalem on the southwest. It was a garbage dump for the city, and the continual burning of refuse there became a metaphor for the final place of judgment for the wicked.

Mark 9:43–48

Most of the best manuscripts do not include [9:44, 46](#), but a few include them. These two verses were almost certainly copied from [9:48](#) and were not in the original text of Mark.

Mark 9:48

The eternity of hell is emphasized by the phrases never die and never goes out (cp. [9:43](#)). The horror of hell is emphasized by its portrayal as a place of everlasting fire, and of decay and corruption where maggots eternally eat everything away. The putrid smell of decay and the presence of maggots in the Valley of Hinnom may lie behind this imagery (see study note on 9:43). This imagery is a powerful warning for people to repent in order to escape the punishment of hell.

Mark 9:49–50

tested with fire: Literally *salted with fire*. The fire of testing has a purifying effect, like salt (see also [1 Pet 1:7](#); [4:12](#); [Rev 3:18](#)). Salt also refers to Christian character. Genuine Christian character will have a genuinely purifying influence. • But if it loses its flavor: The salt mined from the Dead Sea often contained gypsum, so although it looked like perfectly good salt, it was useless. It did not taste salty, and it created a disposal problem.

Mark 10:1–2

The Pharisees' question about divorce was much debated in Judaism, but it had a hostile purpose as

they tried to trap Jesus (see [2:16, 18, 24](#); [7:5](#); [8:11; 12:13](#)). John the Baptist was beheaded over his teaching that Herod Antipas's divorce and remarriage was unlawful ([6:18–19](#)), and according to the Jewish historian Josephus, John was martyred close to Jesus' current location east of the Jordan River, at Herod Antipas's fortress at Machaerus (see [6:28](#); Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.2). If Jesus answered in agreement with John the Baptist, the Pharisees could indict him before Herod. But if Jesus said that divorce was lawful, he would be contradicting a prophet.

Mark 10:3

Jesus answered the Pharisees' trick question with a counter-question (cp. [Matt 22:20](#)).

Mark 10:4

The Pharisees quoted what Moses permitted. There was much debate among rabbis as to what constituted the "something wrong" (see [Deut 24:1](#)) that made divorce permissible. Rabbi Shammai allowed divorce only on the basis of sexual immorality. Rabbi Hillel permitted divorce even if a woman burned her husband's dinner or was less attractive than someone else (*Mishnah Gittin* 9:10).

Mark 10:5–9

God permitted divorce as a concession to the hard hearts of the people. But God's will is more aptly expressed in the passages that Jesus quotes from the law of Moses ([Gen 1:27](#); [2:23–24](#); see also [Mal 2:16](#)). Jesus shows that God delights in marriage, which is the creation of a new union in which two become one. No one should rebel against God's will by seeking to split apart what God has united.

Mark 10:10

Jesus often explained his teaching to his disciples in the privacy of a house (see [7:17](#); [9:28, 33](#)).

Mark 10:11–12

Whoever divorces . . . and marries someone else commits adultery: The parallel in [Luke 16:18](#)

agrees with Mark and mentions no exceptions to this prohibition of divorce, while Matthew's parallel account allows an exception in cases of infidelity ([Matt 19:9](#); see also [Matt 5:32](#)). Paul also allows an exception if an unbelieving partner deserts the marriage ([1 Cor 7:15](#)). Mark's account focuses on the core principles—God hates divorce ([Mal 2:16](#)), marriage is meant to be for life, and divorce betrays the divine purpose of marriage.

Mark 10:13

The ages of the children cannot be determined from this passage. The Greek word *paidia* can refer to a broad spectrum of ages, from a twelve-year-old child ([5:41–42](#)) down to an eight-day-old infant ([Gen 17:12](#), Greek version). • the disciples scolded the parents: See study note on Luke 18:15–17.

Mark 10:13–16

Jesus' love and concern for children has already been seen in [5:41–43](#); [9:36–37](#), [42](#). Jesus uses the incident to teach that the Kingdom of God belongs to those who are like these children.

Mark 10:14–15

Mark does not explain what characteristics of children make them fit for the Kingdom of God; [Matthew 18:4–5](#) suggests that the attributes include humility and the ability to receive things simply.

Mark 10:17

The rich man ([10:22](#)) was a young ruler ([Matt 19:20](#); [Luke 18:18](#)) who showed respect toward Jesus by kneeling and calling Jesus Good Teacher. *Teacher* is a frequent title for Jesus in Mark (see [Mark 4:38](#); [5:35](#); [9:17](#), [38](#); [10:20](#), [35](#); [12:14](#), [19](#), [32](#); [13:1](#); [14:14](#)); the addition of *good* is unique.

Mark 10:17–31

The story of the rich man continues the themes of discipleship begun in [9:33](#) and the requirements for entering the Kingdom of God ([10:13–16](#)). The attitude of the rich man contrasts sharply with the

childlike faith necessary for entering the Kingdom of God.

Mark 10:18

Jesus' reply has troubled interpreters for centuries. Jesus was probably objecting to the man's loose application of the term *good* to any human being, since ultimate goodness and perfection belong to God alone. Without in any way denying his own goodness, Jesus wanted to focus the rich man's attention on God. The rich man wanted to enter the Kingdom of God, and Jesus was contrasting God's goodness with the man's own human sinfulness.

Mark 10:19

Jesus' reply seems strange to Christians who are familiar with Paul's teaching on this subject (e.g., [Rom 3:20](#); [Gal 2:16](#)). In naming five of the Ten Commandments Jesus was not implying that the man could earn eternal life by keeping them; he was telling him what God's standards are and allowing the man to evaluate his own performance. Truly loving God with all one's heart, soul, mind, and strength, and one's neighbor as one's self ([Mark 12:30–31](#)), requires trusting in God's grace, accepting Jesus' sacrificial death on our behalf ([10:45](#); [14:24](#)), and keeping his commands ([John 15:10](#); [1 Jn 2:4](#); [3:22](#)).

Mark 10:20

The man's reply was naive (as to what it really means to keep these commands; see [Matt 5:21–48](#)), but it was not arrogant, as the lack of any rebuke indicates (cp. [Mark 12:13–17](#); [Matt 23:1–36](#)).

Mark 10:21

Instead of having an extended discussion about what it means to truly keep the commandments, Jesus focused on the specific issue that revealed this man's problem. He still lacked one thing: He loved riches more than he loved God, thus breaking the first and most important commandment ([12:29–30](#); [Exod 20:3](#); [Deut 6:5](#)). Entering the Kingdom of God requires repentance ([Mark 1:15](#); [6:12](#)), and Jesus helped this man to understand

exactly what repentance entailed for him. He did not need, as he might have thought, to attain a higher level of personal righteousness. He needed to enter God's Kingdom through repentance and wholehearted love for God, thereby obtaining eternal life. He must deny himself (8:34) and love God first and foremost by giving away his money. For other commands involving a negative [sell all] and a positive [follow me] element, see 1:15, 18, 20; 10:28; see also Acts 2:38; 20:21. • Jesus' command to the rich man was not a universal requirement for entering the Kingdom of God but was addressed to his particular situation. It teaches anyone seeking eternal life that nothing else can come before God; repentance (Mark 1:15; 6:12) requires the removal of anything that we place above God.

Mark 10:22

Mark records the rich man's tragic choice. The man departed, still possessing his earthly riches (Matt 6:19) but lacking eternal treasure (Matt 13:44-46). His demeanor (face fell . . . sad) showed his awareness that his awful choice had brought him sorrow rather than joy.

Mark 10:23-27

Jesus astounded the disciples by reversing the idea, popular at that time, that riches were a sign of God's favor.

Mark 10:24

In response to the disciples' amazement, Jesus addressed them affectionately as dear children.

Mark 10:25

Jesus was emphatically warning that riches are an obstacle to entering the Kingdom of God. The camel was the largest animal in Palestine, the eye of a needle the smallest hole. Some rich people are evidently able to overcome the problem created by riches and follow Jesus, but Jesus' followers came from among the poor more than from the rich. • Explanations about a gate in the Jerusalem wall called the "Eye of the Needle" are ill-conceived. There never was such a gate, and this explanation

loses sight of Jesus' frequent use of hyperbole in his teaching (see also Matt 7:3-5; 23:24).

Mark 10:26

The disciples were astounded: It was generally believed that wealth was a sign of God's blessing that enabled the rich to do good deeds. Accordingly, it was assumed that the rich had an inside track on entering the Kingdom of God. The disciples' question was natural, given this understanding. God's assessment was the opposite of their conventional wisdom.

Mark 10:27

This verse tends to be interpreted in one of two ways: (1) Although salvation by one's own effort is impossible, by God's grace people can be saved through faith (Eph 2:8-10). (2) God can give an unusual grace that enables people to overcome their sinful love of riches and believe. Mark does not explain his understanding.

Mark 10:28

The disciples had done what Jesus told the rich man to do—they had given up everything to follow Jesus (1:16-20; 8:34-38).

Mark 10:29-30

Jesus assured his disciples that they would receive whatever they had given up for him many times over, including a new family in Christ (brothers, sisters, mothers, children) and Christian hospitality (houses). • a hundred times: What is gained in following Jesus far outweighs any loss. And in the world to come they will inherit the eternal life that the rich man desired but did not receive.

Mark 10:31

But many . . . greatest then: The account ends with a proverb, contrasting the way that God understands life and how people generally understand it (for similar sayings, see Matt 20:16; Luke 13:30). For those with eyes to see and ears to

hear ([Mark 4:9-12](#); [8:18](#)), the Kingdom of God has already come, and the overturning of this world's values has begun.

Mark 10:32-34

The disciples' awe and the people's fear cast a dark shadow over what lay ahead, given the hostility of the Jerusalem leaders toward Jesus (see [3:22-30](#); [7:1-13](#)). Taking the disciples aside again, Jesus described the coming events in the greatest detail yet (see also [8:31](#); [9:31](#)). He knew what was about to happen; what awaited him in Jerusalem was neither a tragedy nor fate, but God's will (see [8:31-33](#); [Acts 4:27-28](#)). As the Son of God, Jesus had unique knowledge of his upcoming unique death as the Savior of the world.

Mark 10:33

The leading priests and the teachers of religious law were the human agents who fulfilled God's purpose through their hatred of Jesus. • They did not have the right of capital punishment ([John 18:31](#)), so they had to hand Jesus over to the Romans to carry out the actual execution.

Mark 10:35-45

Following Jesus' third prediction of his suffering ([10:32-33](#)) comes another example of the disciples' failure (see [8:31-33](#); [9:31-34](#)). The first part of the account involves the foolish request of James and John ([10:35-37](#)) and Jesus' reply to them ([10:38-40](#)). Then Jesus explains to the other disciples what greatness and leadership in the Kingdom of God mean ([10:41-44](#)). Jesus' own supreme example of servanthood ([10:45](#)) illustrates and concludes this account.

Mark 10:37

The brothers' request indicates that James and John correctly understood that Jesus was the Messiah (see [8:29](#); [9:2-8](#)). However, they completely misunderstood what it meant to be a leader in God's Kingdom ([10:41-45](#)).

Mark 10:38

The two brothers didn't know what they were asking: To share in his glory, they must share in his suffering as servants. • to drink from the bitter cup: Drinking from a cup is often associated with suffering and death ([Ps 75:8](#); [Isa 51:17, 22](#); [Jer 25:15](#); [49:12](#); [Lam 4:21](#); see also [Mark 14:24, 36](#)). • The baptism of suffering recalls Jesus' total commitment to God's calling at his baptism, and it speaks of the believer's own baptism into Jesus' death, burial, and resurrection ([Rom 6:3-5](#); [Col 2:12](#)).

Mark 10:39

James and John did indeed drink a bitter cup . . . of suffering for Jesus. James died for his faith ([Acts 12:1-5](#)). John died an old man, having experienced persecution (Tertullian, *The Soul* 50; Jerome, *Commentary on Galatians* 6, 10). Yet the death of James and John was not the same as that of Jesus—no believer can die Jesus' death as a vicarious sacrifice for the sins of the world ([Mark 10:45](#)) or experience the divine wrath as he did ([15:34](#)).

Mark 10:40

Whatever James and John would experience, Jesus did not have the authority to grant their request. Only God the Father could (see also [13:32](#)).

Mark 10:41

the ten other disciples . . . were indignant: Perhaps they wanted the special places requested by James and John for themselves. All of Jesus' disciples needed a new understanding of what leadership in God's Kingdom means ([10:42-45](#)).

Mark 10:42-44

The unbelieving world (the rulers in this world) thinks that leadership means lording it over others. Just as Jesus' role as Messiah and Son of God meant suffering and death ([8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:32-34, 45](#)), being his follower involves serving others, not ruling over them ([9:35](#); [John 10:11](#)).

Mark 10:45

Jesus offered his own example to demonstrate what leadership in God's Kingdom means. • Jesus understands his death as a ransom. A ransom was a payment made to free a slave or captive. • The expression for many is probably an allusion to [Isa 53:12](#), where *many* means *all* (cp. [Rom 5:15](#), [18–20](#)). Jesus died as the substitute for all. Later, Jesus would speak of his blood as being poured out for many ([Mark 14:24](#)).

Mark 10:46

they reached Jericho: The journey Jesus began in [10:1](#) was nearing its conclusion. Jericho was the last major city in the Jordan River Valley before Jerusalem. It may be the oldest continually occupied city in the world. In Jesus' day, it was no longer located on the much smaller site of Old Testament times (Tell es-Sultan) but had been moved and greatly enlarged. The road from Jericho up to Jerusalem was steep, with a difference in elevation of about 3,000 feet (about 1,000 meters). • The large crowd following Jesus might have been fellow pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for Passover, but they certainly show Jesus' great popularity and charisma. • A blind beggar . . . was sitting beside the road: This was a good location for collecting alms from religious pilgrims going to Jerusalem.

Mark 10:46–52

The healing of blind Bartimaeus is the last healing miracle recorded in Mark. This event and the healing of the blind man in [8:22–26](#) form bookends around this section (see Mark Book Introduction, "Literary Features"). It is also a bridge to Jesus' entrance into Jerusalem as Israel's Messiah in [11:1–11](#). Bartimaeus's confession (Jesus, Son of David) prepares the reader for the confession of the people upon Jesus' arrival in Jerusalem ([11:10](#)).

Mark 10:47–48

Bartimaeus heard: Jesus' great fame had spread to Jericho, even as it had spread to Gentile areas ([3:8](#)). • Jesus, Son of David: Mark does not explain how Bartimaeus knew of Jesus' Davidic ancestry. Perhaps he knew that Jesus was the Messiah. The blind man, however, did not here associate this title

with political or military goals as did the vast majority of people in his day. Instead, Bartimaeus focused on the fact that Jesus was concerned with bringing God's Kingdom to the poor, maimed, lame, and blind, and he requested mercy and healing ([10:51](#))—which was in harmony with Jesus' own understanding (cp. [Luke 4:18–19](#)).

Mark 10:50

threw aside his coat: Bartimaeus's response is best understood as simply a spontaneous act of joy and anticipation rather than as a symbolic casting off of his old way of life or leaving all to follow Jesus.

Mark 10:51

Bartimaeus's request, I want to see! revealed his faith, without which he might simply have asked for alms. The reports he had heard about Jesus enabled him to cry out for the miracle of sight.

Mark 10:52

The man's faith was rewarded, and he was healed (literally *saved*; see [5:23](#), [28](#), [34](#); [6:56](#); [Matt 9:22](#); [Luke 8:48](#)). The healing was performed without touch, in contrast to the healing of the blind man in [Mark 8:22–26](#). Bartimaeus followed Jesus (see also [1:18](#); [2:14–15](#); [6:1](#); [8:34](#); [10:21](#), [28](#), [32](#)) down the road (cp. [1:2–3](#); [10:32](#)).

Mark 11:1

Jerusalem was Jesus' goal. During the week before his crucifixion, Jesus apparently stayed in Bethany with his disciples ([11:11–12](#); [14:3–9](#)). • The Mount of Olives is frequently associated with the site of the final judgment ([Zech 14:4](#)) and the place where the Messiah will manifest himself ([Ezek 11:23](#); [43:1–5](#); see also Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.8.6). • As he did at other times, Jesus sent two of them (see [Mark 6:7](#)).

Mark 11:1–13:37

This section centers on Jesus' relationship to the Jerusalem Temple. Mark's geographical arrangement places in [11:1–16:8](#) all his accounts of

Jesus' teachings and events associated with Jerusalem. • The section concludes ([13:1-37](#)) with Jesus' second extended teaching discourse (see [4:1-34](#)), now focusing on the destruction of the Temple and the coming of the Son of Man. It is the climax for numerous statements within [11:1-13:37](#) concerning the divine judgment about to fall on Jerusalem and the Temple (see especially [11:12-25](#) and [12:1-12](#)).

Mark 11:2-3

There have already been numerous examples of Jesus' supernatural knowledge ([2:8](#); [3:5](#); [5:30](#), [32](#); [8:17](#), [31](#)), but the people's acceptance of the reply that the Lord needs it ([11:3](#), [6](#)) suggests that Jesus had prearranged it (cp. [14:13-16](#)). Jesus had intentionally planned to enter Jerusalem in fulfillment of [Zech 9:9](#).

Mark 11:3

The Lord needs it and will return it soon: Mark's readers have already seen the word *Lord* used to refer to Jesus ([1:3](#); [2:28](#); [5:19](#); see also [12:36-37](#); [13:35](#)), so they would understand it as referring to the Lord Jesus Christ, who needed the colt (see also [Rom 10:9](#); [Phil 2:11](#)).

Mark 11:4-6

The disciples carried out Jesus' instructions and found things as he had said.

Mark 11:7-8

the colt . . . he sat on it: Cp. [Zech 9:9](#); some of the people undoubtedly understood that they were witnessing the arrival of the Messiah. • The disciples made a seat for Jesus with their outer garments and others spread garments and branches from nearby trees into an honorary pathway for Jesus to ride upon to Jerusalem (see [1 Kgs 1:38-48](#); [2 Kgs 9:13](#)).

Mark 11:9-10

Praise God! (Greek *Hosanna*): By the first century AD, *Hosanna* was no longer used literally as a cry

for rescue from enemies but had become an idiomatic expression of joy and jubilation (cp. "Praise the Lord!" as used today). For the people, it was the exuberant welcome ([Luke 19:38-40](#)) of a famous pilgrim, the prophet from Galilee ([Matt 21:11](#)). The miracle of raising Lazarus from the dead might have contributed to the excitement of the day ([John 12:9-11](#)), but even the disciples did not truly understand this event until later ([John 12:16](#)). For Jesus, though, it was a fulfillment of prophecy. Jesus prepared for the occasion carefully and offered himself to the people of Israel as God's Anointed, the Messiah.

Mark 11:11

The account ends surprisingly: The exuberant crowd disappears and Jesus' actual entrance into the Temple is anticlimactic in comparison to his approach. Apparently, in the minds of the people, nothing important had taken place. Jesus' looking around prepares the reader for God's judgment on the Temple ([11:15-17](#)).

Mark 11:12-25

In the synoptic Gospels, Jesus' messianic entry into Jerusalem is intimately associated with the cleansing of the Temple (see [11:15-17](#); cp. [Matt 21:1-17](#); [Luke 19:28-48](#)). In John, however, the account of the cleansing is recorded early in Jesus' ministry ([John 2:13-22](#)). It is uncertain whether there were two separate cleansings of the Temple (an early event recorded in John and this later event recorded in Matthew, Mark, and Luke) or just one cleansing recorded at different places by John and the synoptic writers. • In Mark's account, the cursing of the fig tree ([Mark 11:12-14](#), [20-25](#)) forms an *inclusio* (bookends) around the cleansing of the Temple ([11:15-19](#)). Mark thus indicates that Jesus' cleansing of the Temple should be interpreted in light of his cursing of the fig tree—as an act of judgment rather than reformation.

Mark 11:13-14

it was too early in the season for fruit: Jesus did not curse the fig tree merely because it lacked fruit. Rather, he was performing a prophetic sign act like those of earlier prophets ([Isa 20](#); [Jer 13:1-11](#); [19:1-13](#); [Ezek 4](#)). Just as Jesus judged the fruitless

fig tree, so too he judged the Temple and the worship of Israel, in which he found no fruit. This judgment was fulfilled in AD 70 with the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple by the Romans.

Mark 11:15-16

When they arrived back: Upon entering the Temple, Jesus was intensely disturbed by the buying and selling of sacrificial animals and by the exchange of money. It was supervised by priests, who alone could certify that a potential sacrificial offering was acceptable. The practice of selling sacrificial animals was meant to ensure that only blemish-free animals were used in the service of the Temple. It was facilitated by setting up exchange tables in areas around Jerusalem, but exchange tables were set up within the Temple itself on the fifteenth of Adar, the month before Passover. Usually the exchange rate involved a 4- to 8-percent commission. Because of the large number of half-shekels (see [Exod 30:11-16](#)) and sacrifices involved, the money exchange and the sale of sacrificial animals was quite profitable. Jewish literature of the time was intensely critical of the priests for accumulating great wealth by robbing the poor. Jesus was not opposed to the Temple nor attacking the sacrificial system ([Mark 1:44](#); [Matt 5:17-19, 23](#); [17:24-27](#); [Luke 17:14](#); [Acts 6:7](#); [21:20-26](#)), but he viewed this profiteering as theft and as desecrating the holy place. • Jesus' actions probably did not affect as large a number of people as is sometimes envisioned. These actions took place in one part of the large Court of the Gentiles and would not have been observed by most people in other parts of the Temple. The lack of interference by the Roman authorities suggests that they did not observe the event or did not regard it as a riot or as insurrection. Furthermore, at Jesus' trial, this action is never mentioned. It was not a massive attempt to stop all such activity, but a symbolic act foretelling the judgment soon to befall the Temple and the city.

Mark 11:15-19

The largest part of the Temple in Jerusalem was the Court of the Gentiles, surrounded by covered porticoes. It was here that this selling probably took place.

Mark 11:16

from using the Temple as a marketplace: Or *from carrying merchandise through the Temple*. The Temple was also defiled by its use as a shortcut for carrying things from one part of the city to another. Other rabbis also forbade this practice (see *Mishnah Berakhot* 9.5; see Josephus, *Against Apion* 2.8).

Mark 11:17

Jesus quoted [Isa 56:7](#) and [Jer 7:11](#) in defense of his action. The first quotation emphasizes the importance of the Temple for Gentiles. God's house was intended by its very architecture (i.e., the Court of the Gentiles) to assist Gentiles in becoming children of Abraham. Jesus' act of judgment fell upon the leaders of Israel for hindering the Gentiles' access to the Temple. They were desecrating the Temple by taking part of the Temple specifically designated as a house of prayer for all nations and turning it into a den of thieves through the profiteering taking place.

Mark 11:18

The leading priests and teachers of religious law plotted to kill Jesus because they feared him. His great influence among the people, the amazement created by his actions, and the influence of his teaching threatened their position (see [3:6](#); [12:12](#); [14:1-2, 10-11](#)). Their response shows that reform was not enough: God's judgment was necessary.

Mark 11:19

Jesus and the disciples left: They presumably returned to Bethany ([11:11](#); [14:3](#)).

Mark 11:20-21

Jesus' miraculous power to judge the fig tree testified to his authority to bring about the judgment of Jerusalem that he had foretold. If Mark's original audience was hearing his Gospel read to them in the late AD 60s, they knew that Roman legions were already enacting this prophetic judgment against Jerusalem.

Mark 11:22-23

The importance of Jesus' words is emphasized by his emphatic I tell you the truth. • This mountain probably indicates the Temple Mount, not the Mount of Olives. The judgment of the Temple is the focus of [11:12-25](#); it will be referred to again in [12:9](#) and at great length in [13:1-37](#). Jesus' reference to destroying the Temple would later be raised at his trial ([14:58](#)) and crucifixion ([15:29](#)).

Mark 11:24-25

Two additional sayings on prayer are tied to [11:23](#) by the word believe. In the first ([11:24](#)), we are told that we will receive what we ask for (see [Matt 7:7](#)) if we pray with the faith described in [Mark 11:23](#). • Forgiveness is the second condition for answered prayer. Only when we forgive others can our most important prayer, that God forgive us, be answered ([Matt 5:23-24](#); [6:12](#), [14-15](#); [Luke 6:37](#); [11:4](#); cp. [Luke 7:41-43](#), [47](#); [Eph 4:32](#); [Col 3:13](#)).

Mark 11:27

Upon returning again to Jerusalem (see [11:1](#), [11](#), [15](#)), Jesus and the disciples entered the Temple. The frequent repetition of Jerusalem reminds readers of what would soon take place there ([10:32-34](#); see [8:31](#); [9:31](#); [14:1-16:8](#)). • In the Temple, Jesus encountered the leading priests, the teachers of religious law, and the elders. These three groups made up the seventy-one-member high council (the ruling body of the nation). From earlier encounters with them ([8:31](#); see also [14:43](#), [53](#); [15:1](#)), we expect them to oppose Jesus.

Mark 11:27-33

Following the cleansing of the Temple ([11:15-17](#); [Matt 21:12-22](#); [Luke 19:45-46](#)), Jesus' opponents question his authority to do so (see also [Matt 21:23-27](#); [Luke 20:1-8](#); cp. [John 2:18-22](#)).

Mark 11:28

Jesus' authority includes his divine authority to cast out demons ([1:22](#), [27](#); [5:1-13](#)), heal ([1:29-2:12](#); [5:21-43](#)), forgive sins ([2:10](#)), and now cleanse the Temple. Jesus' authority clearly was

from God, but the religious leaders were unwilling to accept it.

Mark 11:29-30

Jesus often replied to his opponents with counter-questions (e.g., [2:8-9](#), [19](#), [25-26](#); [3:4](#), [23](#); [10:3](#), [38](#); see also [12:16](#)), which is an effective way both to teach and to refute.

Mark 11:31-32

Jesus clearly placed his opponents in a bind, for either a "yes" or a "no" would damage their reputation and authority in the eyes of the people. Denying John's prophetic authority would probably anger the people. Affirming it would mean that they should have accepted what John said, including what he said about Jesus. This answer would also answer their own question ([11:28](#)).

Mark 11:33

In answering, "We don't know," the religious leaders of the nation admitted that they could not answer a simple question that the people had no difficulty in answering: John was sent from God. They thus forfeited the religious leadership of the nation on this question. Their hardness of heart ([3:5](#); [7:6](#)), their unwillingness to see ([4:12](#)), and their deliberate refusal to accept the truth made further discussion fruitless. Their blindness and hostility toward God's servants John the Baptist and Jesus, their desecration of the Temple, and their plot to kill Jesus all revealed why God's judgment would come within that very generation ([13:30](#)).

Mark 12:1

The antecedent to them is the religious leaders of [11:27](#) (also in [12:12](#)). • The beginning description of the story comes from [Isa 5:1-7](#). Jesus' audience knew the book of Isaiah well and would have immediately recalled this allegory of the vineyard.

Mark 12:1–12

The events of [11:27–12:44](#) all take place in the Temple (see [11:27](#); [13:1](#)). This story (literally *parable*) is intimately tied to the previous question about Jesus' authority ([11:27–33](#)) by the introductory words, Then Jesus began teaching them. This parable is an extended reply by Jesus to the religious leaders. • Jesus intended his audience to interpret this parable in light of [Isa 5:1–7](#), a similar story of someone planting a vineyard, building a lookout tower, putting a fence around the vineyard, and digging a pit for a wine vat. A similar question is asked: What do you suppose the owner of the vineyard will do? ([Mark 12:9](#); cp. [Isa 5:4](#)). Isaiah specifically identifies the vineyard as the people of Israel ([Isa 5:7](#)); Jesus' hearers and Mark's readers would similarly have understood the present story as an allegory about the Israelites. Other details in the story are also clearly meant to be interpreted allegorically: The tenants represent the leaders of Israel; the owner represents God; the servants represent the Old Testament prophets; the beloved son represents Jesus, the Son of God; the murder of the son represents Jesus' crucifixion; and the giving of the vineyard to others represents the judgment coming upon Israel ([Mark 11:15–17](#); [13:1–37](#)). The interpretation would have been more clear to Mark's readers than to Jesus' original audience, but the religious leaders who were Jesus' contemporaries understood it clearly enough that they sought to kill him ([12:12](#)).

Mark 12:2–5

The time of the grape harvest probably refers to the time, some four years after planting, when a new vineyard would produce its first harvest. The owner's share of the crop would have been a quantity of grapes or wine, given in payment for the lease of the vineyard. • In the Old Testament, prophets are often referred to as servants ([Jer 7:25–26](#); [Amos 3:7](#); [Zech 1:6](#)); they were repeatedly mistreated and killed by Israelite leaders ([1 Kgs 18:13](#); [19:10, 14](#); [2 Chr 24:20–27](#); [36:15–16](#); [Jer 26:20–23](#); [Neh 9:26](#); see [Matt 23:34, 37](#); [1 Thes 2:15](#)).

Mark 12:6

Mark's early readers would have immediately associated his son whom he loved dearly with Jesus (cp. [1:11](#); [9:7](#); see also [1:1](#); [3:11](#); [5:7](#)).

Mark 12:7

The reasoning of the tenants is unclear to us, although it was apparently clear to the original hearers, requiring no further explanation (cp. [Matt 21:38](#); [Luke 20:14](#)). Perhaps with the son's coming, they assumed that the father had died and that the murder of the son would leave the vineyard without a living claimant. Then ownership would fall to those who had been working the vineyard for years.

Mark 12:8

threw his body out of the vineyard: The tenants' disgraceful treatment of the son is heightened by their not even burying his body. Cp. [Heb 13:12–13](#).

Mark 12:9

The parable concludes with two rhetorical questions (cp. [3:23, 33](#); [4:13](#); [7:18](#); [8:12](#)). The first corresponds to what the "Lord of Heaven's Armies" says in the parable of the vineyard ([Isa 5:5–7](#)). Although some interpret Jesus' answer as meaning that God would replace the evil Jewish leaders ([Mark 11:27](#); [12:12](#)) with more faithful ones, Mark's readers likely would have understood the others to whom the vineyard would be given as the Gentile church (cp. [Matt 21:43](#); [Rom 9:25–33](#); [11:13–24](#)). Thus, Jesus' parable connects with the coming destruction of Jerusalem ([Mark 11:15–19](#); [13:1–37](#); [14:58](#); [15:29](#)).

Mark 12:10–11

In his second rhetorical question, Jesus used a quotation from [Ps 118:22–23](#). The rejected stone (the Son) had become the cornerstone of God's Kingdom (cp. [Acts 4:11](#); [1 Pet 2:4, 6–7](#)). The phrase is traditionally understood as the buried cornerstone that is part of the foundation, but it could be the capstone at the top of a building that marks its completion. Whichever stone is meant, it

was the most important one. Despite the evil intention of the builders—the religious leaders—all they did was in accordance with God's will ([Acts 4:28](#)), which was wonderful to see. Those who put Jesus to death were God's instruments in his plan for the Son of Man to give his life as a ransom for many ([Mark 10:45](#)).

Mark 12:12

The religious leaders: For the second time, the presence of the crowd thwarted their evil intentions (see [11:31-32](#); [14:1-2](#)).

Mark 12:13-17

Having failed in questioning Jesus' authority, Jesus' enemies tried to alienate his audience. Readers are aware from the beginning that the flattery of the Pharisees and supporters of Herod (see [3:6](#)) was insincere; they wanted only to trap Jesus into saying something for which he could be arrested. The question is it right to pay taxes to Caesar or not? had been carefully thought out by Jesus' opponents. It presented Jesus with a dilemma. To say yes would alienate the people, for they despised the Romans and hated paying them taxes. To say no would make him a revolutionary and force an immediate confrontation with the Roman authorities, resulting in his arrest.

Mark 12:14

taxes: The Greek word refers to a poll tax or head tax; cp. [Luke 2:1-2](#); [Acts 5:37](#).

Mark 12:15

Jesus' surprising reply revealed his wisdom. • a Roman coin: Apparently the poll tax had to be paid in Roman coinage.

Mark 12:16

The picture and title on the coin was almost certainly that of Tiberius Caesar, who reigned from AD 14-37. The inscription read "Tiberius Caesar Augustus, Son of [the] Divine Augustus" on one side and "High Priest" on the other.

Mark 12:17

give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar: Jesus' words cannot be taken as those of an anti-Roman zealot opposing Jewish taxation by Caesar. Jesus clearly indicates elsewhere that he was opposed to the zealot cause (see [Matt 5:9, 39, 41](#); [26:52](#)). However, Jesus' statement cannot be understood as pro-Roman, either, because service to God is fundamental, and God is ultimately over Caesar. Like the evil farmers in the previous parable, the religious leaders had not given God what belonged to him.

Mark 12:18

This is the only place in Mark where the Sadducees are mentioned by name, although they are included in references to the leading priests (see [8:31](#); [10:33](#); [11:18, 27](#)). Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection from the dead (see [Acts 4:1-2](#); [23:8](#)).

Mark 12:18-27

This is the third controversy story of the series begun in [11:27](#). As in most New Testament references to the Sadducees, the setting is the Temple ([Matt 22:23-33](#) // [Luke 20:27-40](#); [Acts 4:1-3](#); [5:12, 17](#); [22:30-23:10](#); the exceptions are [Matt 3:7](#); [16:1-12](#)). • The Sadducees' question ([Mark 12:19-23](#)) was carefully crafted and based on a commandment of Moses ([Deut 25:5-6](#); see [Gen 38:6-11](#); [Ruth 4:1-22](#)). Since all seven men could not have the woman as wife in the resurrection, and since none of them had a special claim, the Sadducees thought that they had proven the absurdity of the doctrine of the resurrection and refuted the Pharisees and Jesus (cp. [Matt 12:41-42](#); [Luke 16:19-31](#); see also [Mark 8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:34](#)).

Mark 12:19

The Sadducees based their views only on the books of Moses. • Like the Pharisees ([12:14](#)), they addressed Jesus as Teacher. The Sadducees were fond of debating with religious teachers (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.1.4).

Mark 12:24–27

Jesus' response had two elements. First, he rebuked the Sadducees' ignorance of the Scriptures (i.e., the Old Testament), where the resurrection of the dead is referred to most clearly in the Prophets ([Isa 26:19](#); [Ezek 37:1–14](#)) and the Writings ([Job 19:26](#); [Pss 16:9–11](#); [49:15](#); [73:23–26](#); [Dan 12:2](#)). However, the Sadducees accepted only the Torah (Genesis—Deuteronomy), so Jesus answered them from the Torah. The reference to God as the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob (see [Exod 3:6](#), [15–16](#)) showed that God's covenant with the patriarchs could not be broken by death. They were still alive ([Matt 8:11–12](#); [13:17](#); [Luke 16:19–31](#); [John 8:56](#)), for God is the God of the living, not the dead. God's covenant relationship with his people extends beyond their physical death, which means that the afterlife must be a reality. • Second, Jesus challenged the Sadducees' ignorance of God's power. They thought that life in the resurrection would have to be an extension of mortal life. Instead, it is life raised to an entirely new level. In this new existence, there is no need for sexual reproduction because there is no more death. The intimacy of marriage is superseded by fellowship with a multitude of fellow believers and with God ([Mark 10:29–30](#); [Matt 19:28–29](#); [Luke 18:29–30](#); [Rev 21:1–4](#)). It is in this respect that resurrected believers will be like the angels in heaven. • Jesus' argument demonstrates his wisdom before his opponents and affirms the hope of the resurrection for his followers. Jesus is “the resurrection and the life” ([John 11:25](#)); he has conquered death and assured those who believe in him that they will “not perish but have eternal life” ([John 3:16](#)).

Mark 12:28

Of all the commandments: The Torah (Genesis—Deuteronomy) contains 613 separate commandments, and Jewish teachers frequently debated about which were more important than others. No command was considered unimportant, but some were recognized as more fundamental than others (see [Matt 22:40](#)). Rabbi Hillel's answer to this question was, “What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor” (*Babylonian Shabbat* 31a; see also *Tobit* 4:15). Other suggestions included [Prov 3:6](#); [Isa 33:15–16](#); [56:1](#); [Amos 5:4](#); [Mic 6:8](#); and [Hab 2:4](#).

Mark 12:28–34

After the three hostile challenges of [11:27–12:27](#), the reader might expect the next question to Jesus to be hostile (see [11:28](#); [12:13](#), [15](#), [19–23](#)), but this was not a hostile counter. Earlier references in Mark to the teachers of religious law have portrayed them as antagonistic ([2:6–7](#), [16](#); [3:22](#); [7:1](#), [5](#); [8:31](#); [9:14](#); [10:33](#); [11:18](#), [27](#)), and Jesus will warn the crowds against their hypocrisy ([12:38–40](#)), but this teacher was positively inclined toward Jesus ([12:28](#), [32](#)) and praised him ([12:32–33](#)). Jesus described the man's answer to his question as having understanding, and Jesus said that the man was not far from the Kingdom of God ([12:34](#)).

Mark 12:29–31

Jesus' reply combined two widely separated commands from the Torah. • The first, [Deut 6:4–5](#), was probably the best known passage in the Old Testament, for it was repeated twice daily by observant Jews. It is called the *Shema* because it begins with the word Listen (Hebrew *shema*). The first command corresponds to the first part of the Ten Commandments ([Exod 20:2–11](#)), which deals with a person's relationship to God. • The oneness of God is foundational to Jewish and Christian monotheism and is the basis for the command to love God with all one's heart (thinking and affection), soul (desire and feeling), mind (understanding), and strength (energy and power). • The second command is from [Lev 19:18](#). It corresponds to the second part of the Ten Commandments ([Exod 20:12–17](#)), which concerns a person's relationship with other people. The second command is based on the natural inclination of people to look after themselves. Its importance to the early church can be seen in its frequent repetition ([Matt 5:43–44](#); [19:19](#); [25:31–46](#); [Rom 13:8–10](#); [Gal 5:14](#); [Jas 2:8](#); *Didache* 1.2; 2.7). The two commands are not independent, but are intimately associated as one commandment. Their integration precludes religious mysticism that addresses only a person's relationship with God or humanism that addresses only human relationships.

Mark 12:32–33

The scribe's affirmation adds emphasis to the importance of these two commands for authentic devotion.

Mark 12:34

The account ends with Jesus' commending the teacher of religious law for recognizing that this twofold command was more important than burnt offerings and sacrifices (see [Hos 6:6](#)). We are left uncertain as to the fate of this man. He was not far from the Kingdom of God, but did he enter it? Mark might have intentionally left this question unanswered so that each reader would wrestle with the question, *Have I entered the Kingdom of God?*

Mark 12:35-37

After having answered various questions, mostly from opponents, Jesus now asked a question (see [8:27](#); [Matt 17:25](#); [21:31](#); [Luke 10:36](#)). The Messiah was considered the son of David because of such passages as [Isa 9:2-7](#); [11:1-5](#); [Jer 23:5-6](#); [33:15-16](#); [Ezek 34:23-24](#); [37:24-28](#). With his question, Jesus did not deny that the Messiah was a descendant of David ([Mark 10:47-48](#); [11:10](#); see [Rom 1:3-4](#)), but he demonstrated that this description, while correct, is inadequate. The Messiah is far more!

Mark 12:36

[Psalm 110:1](#) is the Old Testament verse most quoted in the New Testament. Since David authored the psalm, the statement "The Lord [God] said to my [David's] Lord [the Messiah]" indicates that the Messiah is David's Lord. Thus, the Messiah could not simply be David's son. He is the Son of God who sits at God's right hand ([Mark 14:62](#)) and will come to judge the world ([8:38](#); [13:24-27](#), [32-37](#)).

Mark 12:38-39

teachers of religious law: See [1:22](#). The warning here is similar to the one against the Pharisees and Herod in [8:15](#). The scribes broke the two greatest commands ([12:30-31](#)). They broke the first command by failing to love God and failing to reserve for him alone the reverence and adoration they sought for themselves. • Flowing robes were probably the garments worn by religious men;

respectful greetings perhaps meant being called "Rabbi" (see [Matt 23:7](#)). The seats of honor were in the front of the synagogue facing the congregation.

Mark 12:40

The teachers of religious law broke the second command by failing to love their neighbors, as was seen in their cheating widows of their property. They clearly were cheating the most vulnerable and needy people despite God's concern for widows ([Deut 14:29](#); [Pss 68:5](#); [146:9](#); [Isa 1:17](#); [Jer 7:6](#); [49:11](#)) and his condemnation of those who mistreat them ([Isa 1:23](#); [Ezek 22:7](#); [Zech 7:10](#); [Mal 3:5](#)). The scribes wore a hypocritical cloak of false piety (see [Matt 6:5-6](#); [Luke 18:11-12](#)). • they will be more severely punished: In the final judgment ([Mark 9:42-48](#); see [Luke 14:11](#)).

Mark 12:41-42

The word translated collection box can refer to a building within the Temple compound in which Temple money was stored, but here it refers to one of thirteen money chests into which gifts were placed. As Jesus watched, many rich people put in large sums. Then he noticed a poor widow put in two small coins. (The use of the Roman term *quadrans* supports the view that Mark wrote his Gospel for the church in Rome; see Mark Book Introduction, "Audience.") These two coins were worth one sixty-fourth of a *denarius*, a normal day's pay ([Matt 20:1-2](#)).

Mark 12:41-44

This account of a poor widow highlights the contrast between the falsely pious religious leaders ([12:38-40](#)) and those who truly love God. The emphasis of the passage falls on Jesus' pronouncement, I tell you the truth, in which the widow is described as having given more than the rich.

Mark 12:43-44

Jesus called his disciples to hear his teaching (see [3:23](#); [6:7](#); [8:1](#); [10:42](#); see also [7:14](#); [8:34](#)). Jesus' pronouncement in [12:43](#) revealed a radical difference between his thinking and that of the

world. No one would have named a building after the widow for her gift of two small coins, but Jesus and his Father look at a person's heart ([1 Sam 16:7](#)). The widow was doing exactly what Jesus told the rich young ruler to do ([Mark 10:21](#)) and what he taught his disciples ([1:18](#), [20](#); [8:34-37](#); [10:28-29](#)). Like the woman of [14:3-9](#), the poor widow loved God with all her heart, soul, mind, and strength ([12:30](#)).

Mark 13:1

Leaving the Temple, Jesus was heading to the Mount of Olives ([13:3](#)). • look at these magnificent buildings! The sight of the Temple would have been awe-inspiring. It was the largest temple complex in the world, with immense stones. One stone that has been uncovered in the western wall is estimated to weigh 600 tons. With its white stones, gold trim, and the gold-covered roof, the Temple complex looked like a snow-covered mountain; in the sun it was a blinding sight (Josephus, *War* 5.5.6). The Talmud says that "He who has not seen the temple in its full construction has never seen a glorious building in his life" (*Babylonian Sukkah* 51b).

Mark 13:1-37

This passage brings to a conclusion the section begun at [11:1](#). Israel's failure to produce fruit ([11:12-26](#); [12:38-40](#)) and its leaders' hostility toward God's anointed, the Messiah ([11:1-11](#), [27-33](#); [12:13-17](#), [18-27](#)), would result in judgment and the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple.

Mark 13:2

Jesus' reply to the disciples was shocking. This glorious and massive Temple complex, a symbol of strength and permanence and God's favor for the Jews, would be totally, irrevocably destroyed. • Not one stone will be left on top of another! Jesus' prediction emphasized the total devastation that would result from the Roman army's systematic attack on the entire Temple complex (Josephus, *Antiquities* 6.9.1; 7.1.1.). To say that Jesus' prediction was not fulfilled because some of the foundation stones still stand is to misunderstand the language of prophecy. One does not expect a prophet to say that 97.9% of these stones will be removed! Anyone in the first century who visited

Jerusalem after AD 70 would have acknowledged that Jesus' prediction had been fulfilled.

Mark 13:3-4

Andrew appeared here with the trio, Peter, James, and John ([5:37](#); [9:2](#); [14:33](#)), completing the two sets of brothers ([1:16-20](#); [3:16-18](#)). • Jesus' prediction elicited two questions from the disciples. Although some scholars argue that the second question goes beyond the first in looking to the coming of the Son of Man at the end of the age, it is best to interpret these two questions as focusing on the time and the sign associated with the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple (cp. [13:29-30](#); [Luke 21:7](#)). These questions follow naturally from Jesus' prediction in [Mark 13:2](#). The desire to know the sign reflected the disciples' desire to be forewarned and prepared for all . . . these things.

Mark 13:5-6

Jesus warned his followers not to be misled by the many false messiahs who would come claiming, 'I am the Messiah' and would deceive many into following them. These false claimants would profess to be the long-awaited Jewish Messiah (not Jesus per se) or to speak on the Messiah's behalf. Such claimants included Theudas the Galilean ([Acts 5:36](#)), Simon the son of Gioras, and John of Gischala, who deceived many in the AD 60s.

Mark 13:5-23

This section is often divided into two parts, [13:5-13](#) and [13:14-23](#). The first part is often interpreted as describing the destruction of Jerusalem, which occurred in AD 70, while the second part is taken to describe the coming of the Son of Man in the future. It is best, however, to interpret all of [13:5-23](#) as describing events surrounding the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 because: (1) [13:5-23](#) is Jesus' answer to the two questions ([13:4](#)) that deal with the destruction of Jerusalem ([13:2](#)); (2) The commands to flee Judea ([13:14-16](#)), the woe announced upon pregnant and nursing women ([13:17](#)), and the prayer that it not take place in winter ([13:18](#)) make sense if they refer to the events of AD 70 but not if they refer to the future return of Christ; (3) Three warnings in this passage

([13:5](#), [9](#), [23](#)) tie this passage together and indicate that [13:5-23](#) should be understood as a unit. • The subdivisions of this section are arranged as a chiasm (X-pattern): A: Deceivers claim to be the Messiah ([13:5-6](#)). B: There are reports of fighting and natural disasters ([13:7-8](#)). C: There is persecution of believers ([13:9-13](#)). B': The fighting in Judea and resulting tribulation begin ([13:14-20](#)). A': Deceivers claim to be the Messiah ([13:21-23](#)).

Mark 13:7

The Greek word translated must is also used in [8:31](#). In both instances, God's sovereignty over events is emphasized. • but the end won't follow immediately: These things would occur, and just as birth pains are followed by childbirth, God's judgment on Jerusalem would follow. However, these events did not indicate that it was going to happen right away.

Mark 13:9

The second watch out! warns of persecution that was to come upon Christians (see [6:11](#); [8:34-38](#); [10:30](#); see [4:17](#)). Jewish Christians would be brought before local councils of Jewish leaders, who had authority over Jewish communities. We read of such a council in [Matt 10:17](#) and probably in [Matt 5:22](#) (see also [Acts 4:1-22](#)). • beaten in the synagogues: Paul's beatings in [2 Cor 11:24-25](#) were probably inflicted in the local synagogue. • The followers of Jesus would also be susceptible to trial before governors and kings (see [Acts 23:24; 24:10-27; 25:1-26:32](#)). Such trials were due to their being followers of Jesus ([Mark 13:9, 13](#)), not on account of real wrongdoing (see [1 Pet 4:14-16](#)).

Mark 13:10

Such trials ([13:9, 11](#)) would be a means through which the Good News would be preached to all nations. This would all take place first—i.e., before the destruction of Jerusalem. For Paul's understanding of how the Good News had already been preached to every nation in his day, see [Rom 16:26](#); [Col 1:6, 23](#) (see also [Rom 1:5, 8; 10:18; 15:19, 23](#)).

Mark 13:11

A word of encouragement follows the warning of [13:9](#). Jesus' followers need not fear what they should say in these circumstances. The early followers of Jesus were generally uneducated and without political influence (see [Acts 4:10-17; 1 Cor 1:26](#)), so this assurance would have comforted them. Believers are not prohibited from thinking about what they will say, but they need not worry about it.

Mark 13:12-13

There would be no single group, not even their own families, to whom persecuted Christians could automatically flee or turn for help (see [Matt 10:35-36; Luke 12:53](#)). They would be universally hated because of their allegiance to Jesus (because you are my followers). Those who remain faithful to death (to the end) will be saved from eternal punishment (see also [Mark 8:35; Rev 2:7, 10, 17, 26-28; 3:5, 12, 21](#)).

Mark 13:14

The day is coming when you will see the sacrilegious object that causes desecration: Mark did not explain what this object would be, but Jewish readers in the first century were familiar with the term. The prophet Daniel had foretold that such an object would stand in the Temple in Jerusalem ([Dan 9:27; 11:31](#)), and many Jews understood the events in Jerusalem in 167-164 BC, during the time of Antiochus IV Epiphanes, to be a fulfillment of that prophecy. (The deuterocanonical book of *1 Maccabees*, written about 100 BC, narrates Antiochus's reign and describes how Antiochus and his followers erected a "sacrilegious object causing desecration on top of the altar for burnt offerings," *1 Maccabees* 1:54, 59). • standing where he should not be: In light of the historical background and the reference to Jerusalem ([Mark 13:2, 4](#)) and Judea ([13:14](#)), this clause clearly refers to something inappropriate happening in the Temple in Jerusalem. • (Reader, pay attention!): Mark alerted his original readers to pay attention to his description of this sign, which indicates that the expression required careful thought and discernment. Mark's readers were to look for a sign that was similar to what had happened in the time of Antiochus Epiphanes. • Although the phrase *sacrilegious object that causes desecration* is

grammatically neuter, the word *standing* is grammatically masculine, so it refers to a person and not a thing. Suggestions as to who it might have been include: (1) the emperor Caligula, who in AD 39–40 attempted to erect a statue of himself in the Temple (Josephus, *Antiquities* 12.8.2–3); (2) Pontius Pilate (AD 26–36), who attempted to have the Roman soldiers march into Judea displaying their standards, which were considered idolatrous by Jews (Josephus, *War* 2.9.2–3); (3) the Zealots in AD 69–70, when they committed atrocities in the Temple, appointed an unqualified person as the high priest of the nation, and “came into the sanctuary with polluted feet” (Josephus, *War* 4.3.4–8); (4) the Roman general Titus, who after conquering Jerusalem in AD 70 forced entry into the Temple as well (Josephus, *War* 6.4.7); (5) Titus’s soldiers, who set up their standards in the Temple, sacrificed to them, and proclaimed Titus as emperor (Josephus, *War* 6.6.1); (6) the destruction of the Temple itself in AD 70; or (7) a future event involving the coming of the antichrist (see [2 Thes 2:3–4](#)). The context and source of the expression eliminate several of these theories. In Daniel and *1 Maccabees*, the expression involves the Temple, its altar, and its sacrificial rituals. In [Mark 13:14–20](#), it is a sign for people to flee Judea, and what it refers to must occur while there is still time to flee (i.e., before the Roman army had occupied Judea and besieged Jerusalem). Explanations 1 and 2 are too early to serve as a recognizable sign to flee Judea, they didn’t actually defile the Temple, and the Christians did not flee Jerusalem. Explanations [4–6](#) occurred too late, for there would have been no opportunity to flee after Titus entered Jerusalem. Explanation 7 does not refer to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, which is the subject of [13:14–20](#), and the coming of the antichrist would not be limited to Judea. Explanation 3, however, fits well: It occurred in AD 69–70, shortly before Titus besieged Jerusalem, which would have given Christians a brief opportunity to leave Jerusalem before it was besieged; and it involved actions that defiled the holy place in the Temple. This interpretation also helps to distinguish the sign of the coming disaster (the sacrilegious person) from the disaster itself (the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple). • Then: At the appearance of the sacrilege, those in Judea were to flee to the hills. The early church historian Eusebius tells of a prophetic oracle given to the Jerusalem church that caused them to flee the city before its destruction (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.5.3).

Mark 13:14–20

Jesus now gave the sign requested in [13:4](#) and instructed his followers how to respond when they saw it. In [13:5–13](#), they were told not to be alarmed. Here they are told that those in Judea must flee to the hills.

Mark 13:15–16

A person relaxing on the roof of their Judean home should not even pack after seeing this sign, but come down and flee. Likewise, a person out in the field should not return home to retrieve his coat. Believers were to flee from the approaching Roman army as soon as they saw the sign of [13:14](#). The Roman army did not practice a swift “blitzkrieg” kind of warfare. Their movement tended to be cautious, methodical, and relentless. But Jesus warned against playing a waiting game to see how things would develop.

Mark 13:17

The intensity of the coming disaster is illustrated by the suffering of the most vulnerable. In that day, the joy of motherhood (see [Luke 1:25, 57–59](#)) would be accompanied by terrible trouble.

Mark 13:18

In winter, the wadis (canyon-like riverbeds) are flooded, travel is more difficult, and survival is harder.

Mark 13:19

greater anguish in those days than at any time since God created the world: Such hyperbole is common in Semitic expression; it heightens the terror of that horrible time and should not be taken as an exact statistical analysis of how this suffering ranks alongside other disasters. • And it will never be so great again: The events of [13:14–23](#) would not bring history to an end; history would continue after the destruction of the Temple in AD 70.

Mark 13:20

God's shortening of his timetable for the days of calamity is referred to frequently in intertestamental Jewish literature (e.g., *2 Esdras* 2:13; *2 Baruch* 20:1). This statement emphasizes the horrors of this tribulation experienced by God's people, but also God's mercy in shortening this time. • not a single person will survive: The whole population of Judea might have been destroyed if the days of anguish had been longer. • chosen ones (literally *elect*): Followers of Jesus.

Mark 13:21-23

The larger section ([13:5-23](#)) concludes with another warning about messianic pretenders. Here the pretenders are associated with the events of AD 70, whereas in [13:5-6](#) they were associated with the normal course of events. Along with false messiahs, prophets would appear and perform miraculous signs and wonders ([13:22](#)), hoping to deceive not only the Jews of Judea and Jerusalem but even the Christians (God's chosen ones). Jesus warned his followers not to believe such reports. When the Messiah comes from heaven ([13:26](#)), everyone will see and know it (see [Rev 1:7](#)). • Watch out! This warning unifies the section ([Mark 13:5-23](#)) and brings it to a close. Jesus' teaching in this section was to warn his followers in Judea and Jerusalem not to be misled by false messianic hopes and claims. Many Jews succumbed to such claims in the late AD 60s, and Josephus (*Antiquities* 17.10.8) describes the great harm done by these pretenders, who encouraged the Jewish people to resist the Romans. Nothing should distract Christians from fleeing Judea and Jerusalem when they see the sacrilegious object that causes desecration taking place. • For Mark's readers in Rome, Jesus' message had a different application. Mark wanted his readers to watch out for those who promised timetables for prophecy to be fulfilled. They could not know the time ([13:32](#)), and a frenzy about the second coming of Christ was forbidden, but they were to be alert ([13:33-37](#)) and prepare themselves for persecution ([13:9-13](#); see [8:34-38](#)) according to Jesus' words of encouragement ([13:11](#), [13](#)).

Mark 13:24-25

Some of the language used in the New Testament to describe Jesus' second coming, such as the

"trumpet call of God" ([1 Thes 4:16](#)), appears to be metaphorical, and in the Old Testament, cosmic language is frequently used to describe historical events metaphorically (see [Isa 11:1-9](#); [13:9-11](#); [Jer 4:23-28](#); [Ezek 32:1-16](#)). So it is possible that this imagery could refer to a past event, such as the destruction of Jerusalem, if that is the meaning of [Mark 13:24-27](#). However, the New Testament writers clearly understood the coming of the Son of Man to be the visible and personal return of Jesus in the future (see [Acts 1:9-11](#)).

Mark 13:24-27

At that time, after the anguish of those days: Many scholars argue that the cosmic signs of [13:24-25](#), the coming of the Son of Man in [13:26](#), and the gathering of the chosen ones from throughout the world in [13:27](#) are metaphorical ways of referring to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 and to the vindication of the Son of Man by that event. The traditional interpretation, though, is that, whereas the former material refers to the destruction of Jerusalem, this passage refers to the coming of the Son of Man (the *parousia*) that will occur at the end of history. This interpretation fits better for several reasons: (1) After the anguish of those days means after the destruction of Jerusalem, not during it, and at that time (literally *in those days*) could occur at any time after the events of [13:5-23](#); (2) several words used in [13:26](#) are used elsewhere to describe the coming of the Son of Man: glory ([8:38](#)), power and clouds ([14:62](#)); and (3) in light of the early church's longing and praying for the return of the Lord Jesus ([1 Cor 16:22](#); [Rev 22:20](#)), Mark's readers would have interpreted [Mark 13:26](#) as the second coming of Jesus, which will bring history as we know it to a close. The prophets, Jesus, and the Gospel writers described this event as though seen through a telescope, and the distance between events is unclear; no one knows the time for this event except God himself ([13:32](#)). The events of [13:5-23](#) and [13:24-27](#) are part of the same great, divine act that includes the coming of the Son of Man, his ministry, death, and resurrection, the judgment of Jerusalem in AD 70, and the Son of Man's final coming in glory.

Mark 13:27

The Son of Man, at his coming, will gather his chosen people—those who believe in him and

follow him—from all over the world (see [Zech 2:6](#)) and from the farthest ends of the earth and heaven (see [Deut 13:7](#); [30:4](#); [Isa 42:10](#); [62:11](#)). This hope is expressed frequently in the Old Testament (e.g., [Ps 107:2–3](#); [Isa 11:11–16](#); [27:12–13](#); [43:5–13](#); [49:12](#); [60:1–9](#); [Jer 31:10](#)). For Mark's readers, this passage would have provided encouragement to endure and remain faithful despite the persecutions foretold in [Mark 13:9–13](#). The Son of Man's coming will also bring judgment on the unrighteous ([8:38](#); [13:32–37](#); [Matt 13:41–43](#); [24:36–51](#); [25:1–12](#), [31–46](#)).

Mark 13:28–31

This passage contains the lesson (literally *parable*) of the fig tree ([13:28–30](#)) and two sayings ([13:30–31](#)). It is closely tied to [13:4–23](#) by the words all these things ([13:4](#)) and the expression when you see ([13:29](#); cp. [13:14](#)).

Mark 13:29

his return (literally *he/it is near*): The Greek has no explicit subject, so the choice between “he is near” or “it is near” depends on whether [13:29–30](#) refers to [13:4–23](#) or to [13:24–27](#). The NLT text understands it as referring to the return of the Son of Man. Because words in [13:4](#) are echoed in [13:29](#) and [30](#) (see study note on 13:28–31), others interpret it as referring to the destruction of Jerusalem. Just as the sprouting of the fig tree is a herald of summer, the desolating sacrilege ([13:14](#)) would be a harbinger of Jerusalem's destruction.

Mark 13:30

This generation was to witness the fulfillment of these events. That generation did witness the destruction of Jerusalem. Those, however, who hold that all these things refers to the coming of the Son of Man have to interpret this generation as meaning something other than “people alive at this time.” It could refer to the continued existence of the Jewish people, the whole human race, the Christian community, or the last generation of the end time.

Mark 13:31

Jesus personally guaranteed what he had said. My words include specifically what Jesus said in the whole discourse of [Mark 13:1–37](#). Mark's readers would have understood this as guaranteeing the truth of all Jesus' teachings known to them ([Luke 1:2](#)). Like the Old Testament Scriptures (see [Isa 40:8](#)), Jesus' words are eternal. His teachings are more abiding than the fundamental elements of creation. The basic elements of creation will pass away (see also [Ps 102:25–26](#); [Isa 40:6–8](#); [51:6](#); [Matt 5:18](#); [Luke 16:17](#); [2 Pet 3:7, 10](#); [Rev 20:11](#)), but Jesus' words will never disappear.

Mark 13:32

The statement no one knows the day or hour (cp. [Acts 1:7](#)) introduces the warning to be watchful ([Mark 13:33–37](#)) and discourages speculation. • Jesus refers to himself as the Son, higher than the angels in an ascending hierarchy that begins with no one and ends with only the Father. The authenticity of this saying is assured by the limitation it places on the Son's knowledge, something the early church would not likely have imagined—in the apocryphal gospels (about AD 150–300), the tendency is to exalt and magnify Jesus' divine attributes (e.g., see the *Infancy Gospel of Thomas*). In the miracle of the incarnation, Jesus experienced limitation ([Mark 10:40](#); [13:32](#)). If the Son himself did not know the day or hour, Christians should refrain from seeking such knowledge for themselves.

Mark 13:32–37

Just as [13:28–31](#) seems to pick up the theme of [13:5–23](#) in speaking of the destruction of Jerusalem, [13:32–37](#) apparently picks up the theme of [13:24–27](#) and speaks of the coming of the Son of Man. An introductory warning against speculations concerning the end time ([13:32](#)) is followed by a warning to be on guard because one cannot know the time of the end ([13:33](#)). A story illustrates the need to be ready for the Lord's return ([13:34](#)), and its application repeats the need to watch lest they be found unprepared ([13:35–36](#)); the concluding warning is also for watchfulness ([13:37](#)).

Mark 13:33-37

These verses contain several variations of the same basic warning: Be on guard! Stay alert! and watch. The repetition emphasizes the need to be vigilant.

Mark 13:34-35

The point of the story is not that the return of the Lord is uncertain or unexpected (see [Matt 24:45-51](#); [25:1-30](#); [Luke 12:36-38](#); [19:12-27](#)), but that there will be no sign or warning of his coming. The parable is allegorical in at least two respects, with the master (Greek *kurios*) understood as the Lord [*kurios*] Jesus Christ and the slaves or household servants as the Christian community. But to allegorize the gatekeeper as the apostles or Peter was a post-New Testament development. • in the evening, at midnight, before dawn (literally *the cock's crowing*), or at daybreak: The four periods of the night correspond to the Roman division of the night into four watches of three hours each and simply mean that the master can return at any time during the night.

Mark 13:37

The passage, originally addressed to the disciples (you, see also [13:5](#)), is also directed to all readers of Mark's Gospel (everyone). • Watch for him! Although [13:32-37](#) warns about being ready, the early church experienced this vigilance as a joyous anticipation of "that wonderful day when the glory of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ, will be revealed" ([Titus 2:13](#)). Even Greek Christians in the first century repeated the Aramaic prayer, *Marana tha* ("Come, Lord," see [1 Cor 16:22](#); [Rev 22:20](#)) and today, we still "eagerly look forward to his appearing" ([2 Tim 4:8](#)).

Mark 14:1-2

The plot by the leading priests and teachers of religious law to kill Jesus (see [3:6](#); [11:18](#); [12:12](#)) now comes to a climax.

Mark 14:1-16.8

The final section of Mark is the narrative of Jesus' suffering, death, and resurrection.

Mark 14:3-9

The story of Jesus' being anointed by a woman in Bethany ([14:3-9](#)) sets the scene for events to follow. Luke's account ([Luke 7:36-50](#)) is significantly different and might be a different event. This incident took place in Bethany, two miles east of Jerusalem on the lower, eastern slope of the Mount of Olives, where Jesus apparently stayed when he was in Judea ([Mark 11:1, 11-12](#)). The home belonged to Simon, a former leper (lepers were isolated from society; perhaps he had been healed by Jesus; see [1:40-45](#)). • eating: Or *reclining*. The meal was a banquet, as indicated by their reclining. A woman (see [John 12:3](#)) broke the neck of a sealed, alabaster jar containing expensive perfume (pure nard) and poured it all on Jesus' head (see [Exod 29:4-7](#); [2 Kgs 9:1-6](#)).

Mark 14:4-5

Some (cp. [Matt 26:8](#); [John 12:4-5](#)) were indignant over what they considered a waste of the expensive perfume, said to have been worth a year's wages for the average worker. This large amount of money could have been given to the poor, and it was obligatory to remember the poor during Passover.

Mark 14:6-8

Jesus defended the woman's action. That the disciples would always have the poor among them did not minimize Jesus' concern for the poor. The opportunity to minister directly to Jesus was limited. Only hours remained! She chose the best thing she could do with her perfume.

Mark 14:8

Jesus interprets the woman's action. She had anointed his body in preparation for his burial. Whether the woman was consciously motivated by Jesus' imminent death is unclear; her loving act served the purpose Jesus assigned it.

Mark 14:9

Although Mark does not give the woman's name, her deed ([14:6](#)) is indeed remembered as the story of Jesus is told throughout the world.

Mark 14:10–11

In sharp contrast to the woman, Judas Iscariot, one of the twelve disciples, offered to betray Jesus for money ([Matt 26:15](#); [27:3, 9](#)).

Mark 14:12

The time when the Passover lamb is sacrificed was twilight on the 14th of Nisan ([Exod 12:6](#)). This date falls in March or April each year.

Mark 14:12–32

The preparation for the Passover meal ([14:12–16](#)) introduces the story of the Last Supper ([14:22–25](#)).
 • The Last Supper is associated with the Passover meal ([14:12](#), [14, 16](#); [Matt 26:17–19](#); [Luke 22:7–8, 11, 13, 15](#); cp. [John 18:28; 19:14](#)). Many pilgrims celebrated Passover in Jerusalem, where God's Temple was located (see [Deut 16:2](#)).

Mark 14:13–15

Jesus' instructions to the disciples are similar to those of [11:2–6](#), suggesting that Jesus had prearranged a place for eating the Passover and Last Supper with his disciples. Jesus' careful preparations for this meal emphasize its importance. The two disciples were to prepare the Passover meal, which included the lamb (which had to be slaughtered, skinned, cleaned, and roasted over an open fire), unleavened bread, a bowl of salt water, bitter herbs, and a bowl of a fruit puree, or kharosheth. Enough wine mixed with water was needed so that Jesus and the disciples could each drink four cups to celebrate God's fourfold blessing ([Exod 6:6–7](#)).

Mark 14:17

With the coming of evening, Jesus arrived with the Twelve at the upstairs guest room. "The Twelve"

refers to Jesus' disciples as a group; ten arrived with Jesus, since two of them were already there ([14:13](#)).

Mark 14:18

As they were at the table: The Passover was eaten in a reclining position, as were other banquet meals. During the Passover meal, someone (usually the youngest son) would ask the host, "Why is this night different from other nights?" The father or host would then recount the stories of the Passover and the Exodus ([Deut 26:5–9](#)). The elements of the Passover meal were symbolic. The Passover lamb served as a reminder of the blood of the sacrificial lambs that protected Israelite homes from the angel of death, who visited the firstborn in Egypt ([Exod 12:28–30](#)). Unleavened bread recalled the rapid exodus of God's people ([Exod 12:31–34, 39](#)). The salt water represented the tears of their bondage and the crossing of the Red Sea, and the bitter herbs their slavery. The four cups of wine acknowledged God's fourfold promise in [Exod 6:6–7](#). • The terrible deed of betraying Jesus was more heinous in that the betrayer was one of those eating with him (see [Pss 41:9; 55:12–14](#)).

Mark 14:19

The disciples were shocked and saddened, asking, Am I the one? This is the first they had heard that Jesus would be betrayed (though the reader has known it since [3:19](#)). Jesus maintained his betrayer's anonymity.

Mark 14:21

must die, as the Scriptures declared: See, e.g., [Isa 52:13–53:12](#). Jesus foreknew this betrayal as part of the divine plan (cp. [8:31–33](#)), but his betrayer was condemned. Jesus and the Gospel writers do not explain how God's sovereignty and Judas's human responsibility can coexist, but both are stated without compromise (see [John 19:11](#)).

Mark 14:22–25

The Last Supper began with a blessing. In modern practice, Christians ask God to bless the food; Jews in Jesus' day blessed God for providing the food

with the words, “Blessed are you, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who brings forth bread from the earth.” • this is my body. . . . This is my blood: Some understand these words to mean that the bread and wine are transformed into the very body and blood of Jesus (*transubstantiation*); others, that the bread and wine remain bread and wine but that the real presence of Jesus is found in them (*consubstantiation*). In these two views, when one participates in the Lord’s Supper, one actually eats and drinks the body and blood of Jesus. A third view is that in eating the bread and wine, Christians spiritually feed on Jesus. A fourth view is that the meal is primarily a memorial, and the elements are symbolic of Jesus’ sacrifice on our behalf. See also [John 6:53-63](#) and corresponding study note.

Mark 14:24

The cup of wine represented Jesus’ blood, poured out as a sacrifice ([10:45](#); [Isa 53:12](#)). It initiated the covenant that God has made with his people ([Luke 22:20](#); [1 Cor 11:25](#); see [Exod 24:8](#); [Zech 9:11](#); [Heb 9:18-20](#); [10:26-29](#)). The term many refers to all people (see [Mark 10:45](#); [Rom 5:15-19](#)).

Mark 14:25

the day I drink it new: Jesus will have a great banquet for his followers when he returns and fully establishes the Kingdom of God.

Mark 14:26-27

Then they sang a hymn: It was customary to end the Passover by singing the last part of the *hallel* psalms ([Pss 114-118](#)). • The singing of hymns brought the Passover meal and Last Supper to a conclusion, and Jesus and the disciples departed for the Mount of Olives to spend the night. As they proceeded, Jesus told his disciples that they would all desert him, which had to happen because the Scriptures foretold it. • God will strike the Shepherd: As a result, the sheep (the disciples) would be scattered.

Mark 14:28

Despite predictions of their failure, the account included encouragement and hope. After Jesus was

raised from the dead, he met the disciples in Galilee (see [16:7](#)), where they were forgiven and restored (see [John 21:1-23](#)).

Mark 14:29-31

Peter’s protests and Jesus’ rebuke recall [8:32-33](#). Despite Peter’s protests, his denial took place within a few hours.

Mark 14:32

Gethsemane (Aramaic, “oil press”) remains an olive grove to this day. It is called a garden in [John 18:1](#), and [Luke 22:39](#) indicates that it was a favorite place for Jesus and his disciples.

Mark 14:33-34

Jesus went ahead with Peter, James, and John ([5:37-43](#); [9:2-9](#); see also [13:3](#)) and asked them to watch with him, meaning to agonize with and for him in prayer.

Mark 14:35-36

Jesus fell to the ground to pray because of his deep distress (see [Gen 17:1-3](#); [Lev 9:24](#); [Num 14:5](#); [16:4](#)). Since it was normal to pray out loud, Jesus’ prayer was probably overheard by the three disciples, who would not have fallen asleep immediately. • Jesus addressed God as Abba, Father, indicating their close relationship (see [Rom 8:15](#); [Gal 4:6](#)). • Please take this cup . . . from me: In faith, Jesus expressed his own feelings and desires to the Father. It was not only the physical agony of crucifixion that terrified him, but also the unique death that he would experience. He who knew no sin would experience the wrath of God against sin ([Mark 15:34](#); [2 Cor 5:21](#); [Gal 3:13](#)). • Yet I want your will to be done, not mine: Jesus’ submission to the Father’s will is a model for his followers.

Mark 14:37-38

are you asleep? The question was a rebuke, for Jesus knew that Peter had been sleeping. • Though the spirit is willing to avoid temptation (see [Rom 7:18](#), [22-23](#)), the body (literally *the flesh*, which

denotes the general weakness and vulnerability of humanity) is weak.

Mark 14:41–42

The content of Jesus' prayer was probably the same as before (see [14:35–36](#), [39](#)). The third failure of Peter, James, and John to watch and pray recalls Jesus' prediction that Peter would deny him three times ([14:30](#), [66–72](#)). • The words sleep and have your rest can be interpreted as a command, as in the NLT. Others take it as an exclamation ("You are sleeping and resting!"). Still others take it as a rhetorical question ("Are you sleeping and resting?"). • the time (literally *hour*) has come: The passion of Jesus had begun, the hour for pouring out the blood of the sacrificial lamb ([14:24](#)). This statement coincided with the arrival of Judas and the armed crowd seeking to seize Jesus. Jesus was betrayed into the hands of sinners for whom he willingly went to the cross ([2:17](#); [10:45](#); [14:21](#)). • Up, let's be going: Jesus accepted the cup God had given him. He went out to defeat his enemies by dying for them.

Mark 14:43

Judas's treachery in Jesus' arrest is heightened by the reference to him as one of the twelve disciples. Having agreed with the leading priests to betray Jesus at the right time and place ([14:10–11](#)), he led an armed group to seize Jesus secretly at night apart from the people ([14:1–2](#)). Although they wanted to avoid a conflict, the crowd was large enough to quell any resistance by Jesus or his followers (cp. [Luke 22:52](#); [John 18:3](#)).

Mark 14:44–45

Gethsemane was dark, and Jesus was personally unknown to most of the crowd sent to seize him (see [John 18:7–8](#)), so Judas had given a sign by which he would identify Jesus. Judas addressed Jesus as Rabbi and greeted him with a kiss, a common form of greeting ([1 Sam 10:1](#); [2 Sam 19:39](#); [Luke 7:45](#)).

Mark 14:47

One of the men with Jesus (Peter, see [John 18:10](#)) attempted a hurried defense by slashing off the ear of the high priest's slave (see [Luke 22:50–51](#)).

Mark 14:49

But everything was taking place to fulfill what the Scriptures say about Jesus. Mark thus reassured his readers that these events were part of God's divine plan. See [Isa 53:7–9](#).

Mark 14:50

As Jesus had predicted just hours before ([14:27–31](#)), all his disciples deserted him.

Mark 14:51–52

The account of Jesus' arrest ends with this comment about an unnamed young man. There does not seem to be any theological reason for Mark to record this incident. The explanation that it is an autobiographical detail about Mark is as good as any.

Mark 14:53–54

The leading priests, the elders, and the teachers of religious law were not synonymous with the "entire high council" ([14:55](#); [15:1](#)), or Sanhedrin, but they made up a large part of it. Peter followed Jesus into the high priest's courtyard, where the Sanhedrin was meeting. The stage is set for Peter's denial ([14:66–72](#)).

Mark 14:53–65

The story of Jesus' trial follows immediately upon his arrest. Objections have been raised as to the historicity of the various accounts of Jesus' trial, because of differences of detail from the rules found in the Mishnah tractate *Mishnah Sanhedrin*. However, (1) the Mishnah was written around AD 200, whereas the Gospel of Mark was written in the late 60s, over 130 years earlier; (2) the rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* idealize what later rabbis thought should take place in such trials and do not

necessarily describe what did in fact take place; (3) it is questionable whether the Sadducees leading the Sanhedrin would have followed the Pharisaic rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* (see [Acts 23:6-10](#)); (4) the rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* sometimes conflict with what the Jewish historian Josephus wrote; (5) existing laws of conduct were not necessarily followed—Jesus was being tried by a kangaroo court, in which the sentence was predetermined and only the charge for carrying it out was sought ([Mark 14:55](#)); (6) if we must choose between the trial accounts found in the Gospels and *Mishnah Sanhedrin*, there is no reason to choose the reliability of *Mishnah Sanhedrin* over that of the Gospels.

Mark 14:55-59

The trial took place before the entire high council (Greek *Sanhedrin*), which had seventy members and was led by the high priest. The Gospels portray a formal trial: There was a search for witnesses ([14:55](#)), eyewitness testimony ([14:56-59](#)), Jesus being placed under oath ([Matt 26:63](#)), Jesus being allowed to defend himself ([Mark 14:60](#)), the high priest tearing his robe ([14:63](#)), and the concluding verdict by the Sanhedrin ([14:64](#)). This does not mean that it was a fair trial—the decision to put Jesus to death had already been made. Evidence was not sought to determine the truth, but to obtain a guilty verdict and death sentence. • False witnesses giving false testimony misrepresented what Jesus said about the destruction and rebuilding of the Temple (see [15:29](#); [John 2:19](#); [Acts 6:14](#)). Because the false witnesses contradicted each other, their testimony was unacceptable ([Num 35:30](#); [Deut 17:6](#); [19:15](#)).

Mark 14:60-61

Since the false witnesses failed to agree ([14:56](#)), the high priest sought incriminating testimony from Jesus.

Mark 14:62

I Am: Cp. study note on 6:49-50. The reader has known from the beginning that Jesus was the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#)). This was acknowledged by demons ([1:24](#); [3:11](#); [5:7](#)), by God ([1:11](#); [9:7](#)), and by the disciples ([8:29-30](#)), but this

is the first time that Jesus openly and publicly acknowledged that he was the Messiah. • The second part of Jesus' reply was that he would sit in the place of power at God's right hand, which foretold his resurrection and ascension ([Luke 24:50-51](#); [Acts 1:9-11](#); see [Phil 2:9](#); [Heb 1:3](#)) and his triumphal coming on the clouds of heaven to judge the world. At Jesus' return, roles will be reversed, and those judging the Son of Man will be judged by him.

Mark 14:63-64

The high priest tore his clothing at Jesus' response. This was a judicial act that indicated a guilty verdict and signified that there was no need to find other witnesses. The rest of the Sanhedrin agreed that Jesus was guilty and deserved to die. • Exactly what was blasphemous in Jesus' reply is unclear. Perhaps it was his reply "I Am," which was the way God referred to himself in [Exod 3:14](#) (see [John 8:58](#)). However, Mark is not necessarily repeating the actual words Jesus said at his trial (cp. [Matt 26:64](#); [Luke 22:70](#)), so these words could simply be indicating Jesus' affirmative response to the high priest's question. He was the Messiah, the Son of God. During the second Jewish revolt against Rome, Bar Kokhba (AD 132-135) claimed to be the Messiah, and it was not considered blasphemous. Jesus' identification of himself as the Son of Man cannot have been considered blasphemous, for we have over fifty instances before Jesus' trial in which he used this title, and the charge of blasphemy was never raised. Yet it was too much for the high priest and the Sanhedrin when Jesus clearly claimed to be the Son of Man of [Dan 7:13](#) coming in God's name to judge the world. This declaration was also added to the fact that, during his ministry, Jesus forgave sins ([Mark 2:5-7](#); [Luke 7:48-50](#)), claimed to be the Son of God ([Mark 12:6](#)), pronounced judgment upon the Temple ([14:58](#)), and claimed to be Lord of the Sabbath ([2:28](#)). Already convinced that Jesus should be put to death, the religious leaders now pronounced the predetermined guilty verdict ([14:55](#)).

Mark 14:65

spit: See [10:34](#). • Prophecy: See [6:4](#), [15](#); [8:28](#); [14:58](#). • Similar abuse would follow his trial before Pontius Pilate ([15:16-20](#)).

Mark 14:66–72

Peter's predicted denials (see [14:30](#)) occurred during Jesus' trial.

Mark 14:67

The title Jesus of Nazareth might have been contemptuous, for Judeans held a low view of Galileans ([John 1:46](#); [7:41](#), [52](#)).

Mark 14:68

Peter denied that he knew Jesus. To escape further questions, he left the courtyard and went to the entryway.

Mark 14:69–70

The servant girl repeated her accusation to other bystanders. The others thought Peter was Jesus' follower because he was a Galilean (see [Matt 26:73](#); cp. [Acts 2:7](#)).

Mark 14:71

Peter swore: He took an oath that his denial was true.

Mark 14:72

Upon Peter's third denial, the rooster crowed the second time and Jesus' prediction was fulfilled ([14:30](#)). While Jesus stood boldly before the Sanhedrin, Peter quailed before those with little power, cursed Jesus, and swore that he did not know him. Recalling Jesus' words, Peter wept.

Mark 15:1

Very early in the morning: Roman trials usually began at dawn. It is not clear whether this was a second meeting of the entire high council, or whether the account refers back to the decision of the council in [14:63–64](#) and resumes at this point. • Since the high council lacked authority to institute capital punishment ([John 18:31](#)), they had to take Jesus to Pilate, the Roman governor of Judea from

AD 26–36. Pilate's normal residence was on the coast at Caesarea, but he stayed in Jerusalem during Passover, when Israel's celebration of the Exodus raised hopes of deliverance from Roman rule.

Mark 15:1–15

Following the story of Peter's denial, Mark turns back to Jesus and what happened at his trial. Pilate's wavering under pressure fits what is known of him from other sources.

Mark 15:2

The phrase king of the Jews is the Gentile equivalent of the Jewish title, "King of Israel" ([15:32](#)). • You have said it: Jesus' reply to Pilate's question is found in all four Gospels; Jesus clearly understood himself to be a king ([10:37–38](#); [11:9–10](#); [12:35–37](#)), and Pilate eventually crucified him on this charge ([15:26](#)), although Pilate understood that Jesus was not a political threat ([John 18:33–39](#)).

Mark 15:3–5

Pilate sought a self-defense from Jesus concerning the charges.

Mark 15:6–8

The custom described in [15:6–8](#) is not known outside of the Gospels, but all four Gospels refer to it ([Matt 27:15–21](#); [Luke 23:18–25](#); [John 18:37–40](#)); in many instances prisoners in the ancient world were released on special holidays. • Barabbas: See also [Matt 27:16–17](#); [Luke 23:19](#). • who had committed murder in an uprising: Pilate's willingness to release Barabbas ([Matt 15:15](#)) probably indicates that he had not killed Roman citizens or soldiers.

Mark 15:9–14

Pilate apparently hoped to release Jesus, but the crowd was stirred up beyond discussion.

Mark 15:15

to pacify the crowd: To protect his job, Pilate ordered a completely innocent man to be crucified.

- He ordered Jesus flogged: Flogging was preliminary to crucifixion. It was done with leather thongs tipped with metal, stone, or bone. This laceration of the flesh could itself bring death. Jesus' prediction in [10:34](#) was now being fulfilled.

Mark 15:16

The entire regiment (literally *cohort*, one-tenth of a legion) was about 600 men. Those called out were probably all the soldiers currently on duty in the Praetorium.

Mark 15:16–41

The crucifixion account is one of the most historically certain accounts of ancient history. Why would the early church create a story in which the object of their faith was crucified? This story was and still is an offense to Jews and absurd nonsense to Gentiles ([1 Cor 1:23](#)).

Mark 15:17

a purple robe: Purple cloth, made with an expensive dye, was worn by royalty and other wealthy individuals ([Luke 16:19](#); *1 Maccabees* 10:20, 62; 11:58). This robe may have been a centurion's out-of-service robe.

Mark 15:18

King of the Jews: The formal charge ([15:2](#)) on which Jesus was convicted ([15:26](#)).

Mark 15:21–22

After they left the walled city of Jerusalem, Jesus' strength apparently failed. The Roman soldiers forced Simon . . . from Cyrene in northern Africa to carry Jesus' cross (cp. [Matt 5:41](#)). Normally, a crucifixion victim was forced to carry the horizontal crossbeam (the *patibulum*) of his own cross to the place of execution. The vertical post (the *staticulum*) was sometimes left permanently

in the ground as a warning and deterrent (like a hangman's scaffold in a public square). • Simon was the father of Alexander and Rufus, who were probably known to Mark's readers (cp. [Rom 16:13](#)). • Golgotha is Aramaic, meaning Place of the Skull. In the Latin Vulgate, "skull" is *calvariae* ("Calvary"). In Jesus' day, Golgotha lay outside the walled city of Jerusalem ([John 19:20](#); see [Matt 27:32](#); [Heb 13:12](#)). When Herod Antipas later enlarged the city with the so-called third wall, Golgotha was enclosed.

Mark 15:23

Whether Jesus was offered a drink of wine drugged with myrrh in kindness ([Prov 31:6](#)) or in mockery is uncertain. Jesus refused the drink, for he had committed himself to drinking the cup that God had given him ([Mark 10:38–39](#); [14:36](#)). • Myrrh has been used since before Jesus' time to treat wounds and infections and for digestive ailments.

Mark 15:24

Crucifixion goes back to the Medes and Persians in the 600s BC. It spread to the eastern Mediterranean world in the 300s BC through Alexander the Great and became the dominant form of capital punishment in the Roman Empire until AD 337, when it was banned by Constantine. It was slow, shameful, and torturous. The victim sometimes lived for days, and crows and dogs would feed on the victims even before they died. A person could be fixed to the cross by ropes or, as with Jesus ([Luke 24:39](#); [John 20:25, 27](#); see [Col 2:14](#)), by nails between the bones of the victim's wrists. To prevent premature death by asphyxiation, a footrest or a seat was often placed on the vertical beam. • All four Gospels report that the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves.

Mark 15:25

Mark records Jesus' crucifixion as occurring at the third hour, or nine o'clock in the morning. [John 19:14](#) gives the time as around the sixth hour, or noon. These are rough estimates of time, and events in the later morning were typically described as occurring around either the third ([Matt 20:3](#); [Acts 2:15](#)) or sixth hour ([Mark 15:33](#);

[Matt 20:5](#); [27:45](#); [Luke 23:44](#); [John 4:6](#); [19:14](#); [Acts 10:9](#)).

Mark 15:26

Although the title King of the Jews was intended to mock Jesus, it was accurate and meaningful for Mark.

Mark 15:27

Two revolutionaries: Jesus, the most important victim, was placed in the center.

Mark 15:29–32

Jesus was being mocked and abused by the people passing by, the religious leaders, and the revolutionaries. • The people passing by shouted abuse (literally *blasphemed*), wagged their heads in contempt (see [Lam 2:15](#)), and ridiculed his claim that he would destroy the Temple (see [Mark 14:58](#)).

Mark 15:32

The two men who were crucified with Jesus also mocked him. One might expect compassion from those suffering a similar cruel fate (cp. [Luke 23:39–43](#)).

Mark 15:33

At noon (literally *the sixth hour*) darkness came over the whole land until three o'clock (literally *the ninth hour*). The whole land probably means all of Judah. The darkness was both literal and symbolic—it revealed the sinister nature of what was happening and was a taste of the judgment that Jesus predicted would come upon Israel (see [13:1–31](#); [14:58](#); [15:29](#)).

Mark 15:34

Eloi, Eloi . . . why have you abandoned me: Jesus' loud cry is reported in its original Aramaic and then translated for Greek readers. • "My God, my God,

why have you abandoned me?" Jesus quotes [Ps 22:1](#). This saying is best interpreted in light of [Mark 14:27](#); [Ps 22](#); [Isa 53:10](#); [2 Cor 5:21](#); and [Gal 3:13](#). The divine purpose in Jesus' becoming a ransom for many ([Mark 10:45](#)) was now being realized.

Mark 15:35–36

The Aramaic term *Eloi* and its Hebrew equivalent *Eli* ([Matt 27:46](#)) sound sufficiently close to "Elijah" that some bystanders thought that Jesus was calling out for the prophet Elijah to rescue him (see [Mal 4:5](#)).

Mark 15:37

The death of Jesus, like the crucifixion, is told with stark simplicity.

Mark 15:38

The curtain that was torn in two might have been the one that separated the sanctuary from the courtyard (a magnificent tapestry eighty feet tall) or the one that separated the Most Holy Place from the rest of the sanctuary. If it was the former, the tearing (like the darkness, [15:33](#)) was visible to people; it would indicate that Jesus' prediction of the sanctuary's destruction ([14:58](#); [15:29](#)) was being fulfilled spiritually (see [Rom 9–11](#)) but awaited physical fulfillment in AD 70. If it was the interior curtain that tore, it was probably a sign that, just as the heavens were split for Jesus to reveal his direct access to God (see study note on Mark 1:10), his death now extended this access to his followers (see [Heb 6:19–20](#); [9:3–14](#); [10:19–20](#)).

Mark 15:39

the Roman officer: Literally *the centurion*. The Latin word *centurion* refers to an officer in charge of 100 men. • Jesus as the Son of God was announced by God ([1:11](#); [9:7](#)), by demons ([1:24](#); [34](#); [3:11](#); [5:7](#)), by Mark ([1:1](#)), by Jesus himself ([12:6](#); [13:32](#); [14:61–62](#)), and now by a Gentile officer.

Mark 15:40-41

These women had supplied some of Jesus' economic needs (see [Luke 8:2-3](#)). They were also present at the burial ([Mark 15:47](#)) and the empty tomb ([16:1-8](#)) and would be the first witnesses of Jesus' resurrection. • Mary Magdalene, from the village of Magdala near the shore of the Sea of Galilee, was a key figure in the resurrection accounts ([16:1, 9](#); [Matt 28:1](#); [Luke 24:10](#); [John 20:1, 11-18](#)). • Mary (the mother of James the younger): This James might have been James the son of Alphaeus ([Mark 3:18](#)). • Salome is mentioned only here and in [Mark 16:1](#).

Mark 15:43-45

Joseph of Arimathea (possibly from the village of Ramathaim, twenty miles northwest of Jerusalem) was an honored member of the high council and a secret disciple of Jesus who was waiting for the Kingdom of God to come (see [Matt 27:57](#); [Luke 23:50-51](#); [John 19:38](#)). He courageously requested the body of Jesus from Pilate for burial. Since he was a member of the high council and was not known to be Jesus' disciple, it served Rome's purposes to grant his request: It would satisfy Jewish concerns about leaving the dead exposed after sunset ([Deut 21:22-23](#)), and Jesus' disciples would not receive the body.

Mark 15:46

Joseph prepared Jesus' body for burial and laid it in his own tomb (see [Matt 27:60](#)).

Mark 16:1

At the end of the Sabbath at sunset, the shops reopened and the women were able to buy burial spices to anoint Jesus' body ([16:1](#)). Their purpose was not to embalm the body, but to alleviate the stench that a decaying body would create. • The women were clearly not anticipating Jesus' resurrection. Even the empty tomb would fail to convince them that Jesus had been raised from the dead ([John 20:2, 11-15](#)).

Mark 16:3-4

The women wondered how the large stone sealing the tomb could be removed. God had already rolled the stone away to let the women and disciples in.

Mark 16:7

The angel's message for the disciples repeated Jesus' prediction and promise ([14:28](#)). The disciples' desertion and denial would be forgiven and their apostolic commission restored.

Mark 16:8

The account ends with the women fleeing the tomb in bewilderment. • said nothing to anyone: This can be understood positively (they were not distracted from their commission to tell the disciples, [16:7](#); cp. [Luke 10:4](#); [2 Kgs 4:29](#)) or negatively (they failed to deliver the message). Cp. [Luke 24:5-11](#); [John 20:1-2, 18](#).

Mark 16:9-20

Nearly all scholars agree that Mark did not write the "shorter" and "longer" endings. There are clear differences in their style, vocabulary, and theology. Also, the best two available Greek manuscripts (*Codex Sinaiticus* and *Codex Vaticanus*) lack these endings. However, there is reason to doubt that Mark intended to end his Gospel at [16:8](#): (1) Mark emphasizes the fulfillment of Jesus' predictions throughout his Gospel, and if the Gospel ended with [16:8](#), there would be no reference to the resurrection appearance(s) of Jesus; (2) all the other Gospels contain accounts of Jesus' appearances to the women and the disciples; (3) early readers of Mark evidently did not think the book could have ended with [16:8](#), because they wrote these endings; (4) there is no convincing explanation as to why Mark would have wanted to end his Gospel at [16:8](#) (all such explanations sound like modern existential literary interpretations that revel in paradox, very unlike the way a first-century Christian author would have thought); (5) it is strange for a Gospel to begin with a bold proclamation that Jesus is the Messiah ([1:1](#)) and end with the women's fear; (6) it would be unique for an ancient Greek book to end with gar ("because") as the last word—no other example of

this has been found; and (7) [16:7](#) raises the expectation that the disciples will meet Jesus in Galilee—if [16:8](#) was the original ending of Mark, it is the only unfulfilled prediction in the Gospel. Many scholars conclude that the original ending was accidentally torn off and lost, or was never finished.